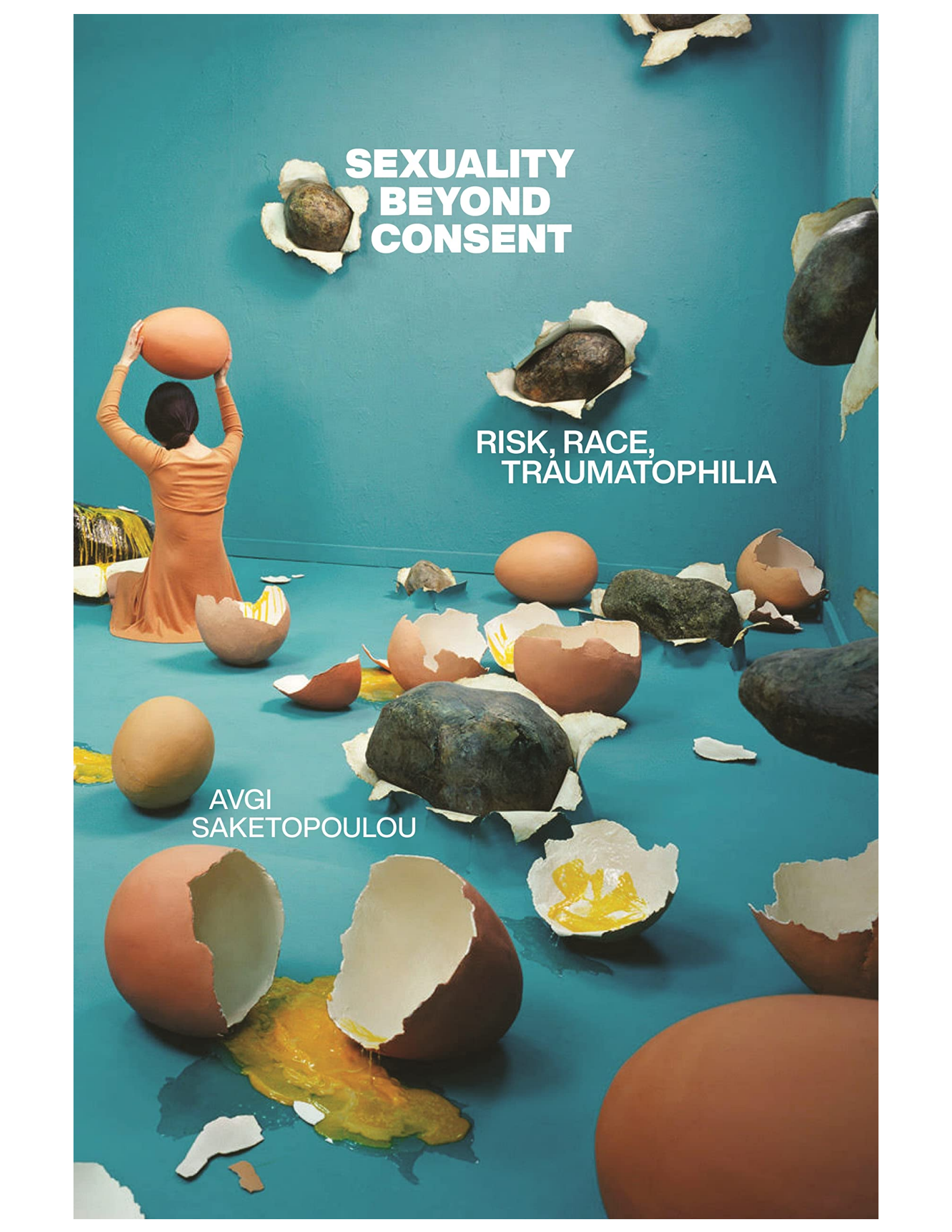


An art installation by Avgi Saketopoulou. A woman in a long, form-fitting orange dress stands with her back to the camera, holding a large, whole brown egg above her head with both hands. She is in a room with teal walls and floor. The floor is covered with numerous broken eggshells, some of which are cracked open to reveal a bright yellow interior. Several dark, smooth, rounded objects, resembling stones or large eggs, are scattered on the floor and attached to the wall. The wall has several holes, some of which contain these dark objects. The overall scene suggests themes of fragility, risk, and the aftermath of an event.

SEXUALITY BEYOND CONSENT

RISK, RACE,
TRAUMATOPHILIA

AVGI
SAKETOPOULOU

To Suffer Pleasure

Limit Experience and Transgression

But, we have to ask, can there be experiences worthy of the name, experiences without the robust, integrated subject, which deny presence, plenitude, interior depth, and narrative completion? Can there be a non-phenomenological notion of an experience that isn't so much actively "lived" as [it is] suffered and endured?

—Martin Jay, *Modernism and the Retreat from Form*

Abjection, a Sexual Lure

In the fourth year of Adam's four-times-weekly psychoanalysis, he described the following experience to me: he and his lover were in a foreign country, visiting a bathhouse. Adam was in a sling when a stranger walked into the room. The stranger's whole being screamed abjection: he wore a yellowed, stained jockstrap; his hair was noticeably greasy; and he reeked of cigarettes. Adam found this man ugly, instantly repulsive. He began to feel queasy. His lover left the room in disgust. Adam hesitated. He, too, had the urge to leave but felt himself strangely compelled "torn between my repulsion and the desire opening up in my body." Adam stayed in the room, "transfixed by this filthy man." My patient not only had sex with this abject stranger—though what exactly he meant by "sex," I never found out—but the experience, he told me, was intensely memorable. When orgasm came, he said, "I exploded into thousands of tiny pieces, was hanging out in space like overheated pieces of dust."

Adam savored this experience. In its aftermath, however, he became considerably distressed that the suffering of disgust had so voluptuously

potentiated his pleasure. In having stayed in the room and given himself over to the experience animated by his revulsion, Adam had violated something that, to him, was taboo. Adam had made contact with something opaque in himself: staying in the room with this man had felt absolutely necessary to him. His sexual contact with this man also markedly contrasted how Adam understood himself to inhabit his White, middle-class gayness: clean, organized, “together.” Straining to account for the way his lush repugnance animated the intensity of his orgasm, he vaguely recalled that this appalling, malodorous man was extravagantly endowed. I was not convinced that size was key and wondered if size were not being retroactively revised to spare Adam the mortification that such a phenomenal orgasm could be caused by the welding of pleasure with disgust.¹ I mention this to underscore that while the theoretical notion that revulsion quickens the erotic was not new to me, my conceptual familiarity did not help me to have something cogent to say about how or why *his* sexual pleasure had become so erotically ionized. At the time, Adam and I were both looking for explanations that would make his desires more legible and his motives more transparent—which is another way of saying that when I was working with Adam, I was still an inexperienced analyst.

For the anthropologist Mary Douglas (1966), revulsion issues from the impulse to purify oneself. Establishing a taxonomy of cleanliness versus dirt and contamination, she argued that something is kept pure and untainted (clean, hygienically organized, together, like Adam) by systematically expelling anything deemed to be out of place (soiled, greasy, abject, like Adam’s stranger). For the psychoanalyst Muriel Dimen, sexual disgust has to do with affect: “when passion runs high,” she writes, “the balance between love and hate swings nauseatingly” (2005, p. 16). This is where abjection comes in. Within abjection, the psychoanalyst Julia Kristeva intervenes, loom “dark revolts of being, directed against a threat that seems to emanate from an exorbitant outside or inside, ejected beyond the scope of the possible, the tolerable, the thinkable. It lies there, quite close, but it cannot be assimilated” (1982, p. 1). Resisting such revolts is ego-constitutive, helping to consolidate the ego’s durable belief in its dominant power over others *and over the rest of the self*. Critical to abjection for Kristeva, as well as for Bataille (1934), is the relationship to our bodies’ excess—mucus, snot, puss, pimples, menstrual

blood, shit, saliva—which is one of disavowal. We are drawn to these bodily excrements and where we repudiate that draw, disgust arises. For Bataille in particular, the excision of such appetites came hand in hand with human beings becoming “civilized,” in our moving away from our animality. On the larger landscape of social relations, abjecting the heterogeneous “other” from the body politic establishes (the illusion of) a homogeneous social order—a project with gender, racial, and class undertones (Tyler, 2013). This, Davis and Dean argue, is also where the problem with democracy and the problem of the sexual converge: both involve elements that are antithetical to the orderly way in which we like to think democratic politics and ethical sexuality (2022). Becoming objects of revulsive hatred as well as ecstatic attraction, the unpalatable elements are excluded, but this exclusion is not “successful” once and for all. It requires constant monitoring. Consider, for instance, how “the invocation of ‘Mexican rapists,’ ‘nasty women,’ and a news anchor accused of ‘bleeding from her wherever’ can aid in restoring the ultimate sovereign white male subject” (Hennefeld & Sammond, 2020, p. 2). The abject trades in repudiation; it traffics in turning away from opacity—and that makes a sustained inquiry into abjection politically necessary. These ideas helped me think about Adam’s experience more complexly—for example, I now wondered about how he had read this man’s race. This offered the analysis the possibility to probe Adam’s Whiteness, and we began to see how he relied on it to consolidate a sense of himself as fundamentally good and pure.

It soon became clear that Adam’s sexual encounter had been more than just sensually intoxicating: something transformative was unfolding. Humiliated, yet intensely curious about how the pleasure of abjection spiked his erotic enjoyment, Adam brought to his analysis bits of sensation that were strewn into the moments when he had come undone. These experiential fragments could not be gathered into language well: there was a semihallucinated impression (a fuzzy black object), a distantly reverberating sound (a voice? a cry? he was not sure), a skin sensation he could not place (not a shudder, more like a jolt). Elusive, these surplus meanings set in motion an exploratory process, which revealed them to be momentous for Adam.

Adam’s clinical story, in its conjunction between eroticism and abjection, starts us out in the midst of the mess that the sexual is—or,

rather, in the midst of the exuberant, generative, unsettling, and challenging mess that sexuality can become when the undecipherable occurs, when one bears the unease of having enjoyed the indignities of sensual pleasures whose memories do not cave under the most strident superego chastisements, delights whose intensities refuse to shrivel under the thick crust of shame. Maintaining a hospitable proximity to such experiences involves resisting the more ordinary tendency to drag them out of their opaqueness to shine on them the light of “insight.” This tendency is not unique to the clinical situation: it permeates much theorizing around the erotic overall. To be clear, I am not arguing that nothing can be gleaned from querying what enthralls us erotically, just that such inquiries can only produce intelligible answers that have first passed through the bottleneck of what can be psychically represented (“translated,” as we will soon see). The sexual, however, is not meaningful but precisely that which cannot be organized through meaning. The erotic, we might say, has more to do with what appears as an *effect of the unconscious*, when we bend our will to allow ourselves to be disarmed in the encounter with our own and the other’s opacity. Said differently, Adam probably found himself disarmed, exploding into pieces of dust, because he was in that friction zone between the opacity of the other (the man was literally a stranger to Adam) and his own. The sexual unease of his disgust, we might say, defamiliarized him *from himself*.

This friction zone between opacities is critical: an exclusive preoccupation with the other’s opacity, without the implication of one’s own, is a turning away from the erotic. This is one way to think about the ethics of sexual objectification: the problem is not when the other is treated in a sexually objectifying way—being turned into a part-object rather than a full human being, as we will see, is how the sexual drive operates, and many people enjoy being treated that way in sex—but in an objectification of the other that is accompanied by a refusal to come into contact with one’s own opacity. The fact that Adam remained in the “friction zone of opacities” is what makes his encounter deeply ethical—but no sooner do I say this than I feel anxious. I am not interested in instituting universal laws to steer ethical relations but in how we may become receptive to our own alterity when relating to others. If there is something deeply ethical about such moments (and I think there is), it has less to do with these encounters being drafted mutually and consensually and

more to do with what arises spontaneously in the encounter, not as deliberate, planned action or to evidence “good politics.” Such intentionality is actually at odds with the state of being disarmed of one’s ego that is critical to the ethics of such experiences. My goal is to navigate perversity’s foothold in the unconscious and the way that the bending of the will—remember that Adam wanted to leave the room—can open us up to aesthetic experience.² Such experience, as our discussion of Moten in the introduction presaged, has deep ties to the ethical not as legislative attempt but as a susceptibility to our own unconscious.

Polymorphous Perversity

In Freud’s early drafts of *Three Essays*, polymorphous perversity is integral to infantile sexuality, and infantile sexuality is the lining that runs through all psychic life (Van Haute & Westerink, 2016). The infantile sexual is not genital: it is dispersed across the skin’s surface; it is not organized heteroprocreatively but has diffuse aims; it has exchangeable objects; it is not concerned with the other as a whole person but is oriented, instead, toward body parts (“part-objects”). If the sexual drive, in its very ontology, is concerned with part-objects, we begin to see that infantile sexuality complicates questions around the ethics of objectification or fetishism. Further, its temporality cannot be plotted in chronological time but proceeds, rather, in repetitive spurts and in nonlinear movements. In that sense, perverse sexualities pulsate on “the temporal tangle,” they ask “about the temporal leak, and about the many questions that attend time’s returns” (Schneider, 2011, p. 10). I purposefully invoke Rebecca Schneider’s work to underscore the imbrication between the force of the infantile sexual and some performance. The polymorphously perverse, I argue, surges through some theater—though not so much through the themes it tackles but via the exigency with which the art and its themes *act on us*. In that sense, some performance re-presents the infantile sexual (Scarfone, 2015b), though not in the citational sense of “twice-behaved behavior” (Schechner, 1985, p. 36) or as in reenactment (Pellegrini & Shimakawa, 2018; Schneider, 2011) but by exciting us. By “exciting,” I do not mean that it enthuses us or that it turns us on, though these may also happen, but in the etymological sense: to excite, Jean-François Lyotard writes, comes from *citare*, which

means “to set in motion, to arouse,” and from *ex-*, “to bring forth, . . . to awaken” (2002, p. 23). That action, as we will explore in chapters 4 and 5, is especially pronounced in forms of performance that excite our perversity. Putting the erotic in conversation with the iterative modalities of time (Chambers-Letson, 2020; Colbert, Jones, & Vogel, 2020; Pellegrini & Shimakawa, 2018), I zero in on the kind of art that Jennifer Doyle has described as difficult and as provoking moral outrage (2013).

Restless and pervasive, the infantile sexual is not something we outgrow or mature out of (Scarfone, 2014), it remains boundlessly energetic inside us. Beyond the limits of gender, sexual difference, and reproduction, it is not a sexuality that seeks climax but ever-intensifying tension. I am recuperating the quintessentially psychoanalytic idea of polymorphous perversity because staying connected with the theory of infantile sexuality will help us refrain from futile efforts to understand the force of perversity by reducing it to a behavioral set of sexualities that need to, or can, be explicated. Rather, I argue for perversity as an erotic possibility with political potential, the vicissitudes of which deserve the effort and nuance of our critical attention. In making this claim, I follow the psychoanalyst Ken Corbett, who, in 1997, urged us not to ask “why” homosexuality but “how” homosexuality, an intervention more recently repurposed by the psychoanalyst Griffin Hansbury in regard to trans experience (2017). Hanbury asks not “why” trans (that is, what “causes” or “explains” trans) but what do people do with their transness and to what effects. Arguing in favor of “how” perversity may seem outdated in today’s academic landscape—even in some (small) pockets of the psychoanalytic world. But I insist on it because the press to locate origin stories that account for the nonnormative is nowhere near extinct even in progressive circles (if you are unsure that this is still the case, wait until we get to the discussion of *Slave Play* in chapter 3 and to the conversation of *The Night Porter* in chapter 5). Asking “why” exceptionalizes perversity when perversity is ever present. To me, the more interesting questions regarding perversion ask after the forms in which the perverse manifests itself and after the way it acquires its particular shape. For Freud, perversion “is something innate in everyone” (1905b, p. 171); what varies is only its intensity and the shape it takes to appear phenomenally. By that statement, Freud did not mean that everyone is a behavioral pervert (not that there would be anything wrong with that) but that all

sexuality, independently of its behavioral expression, has the alien and the perverse swirled in it. If the perverse underwrites all sexuality, rather than ask perversity to account for itself, we might, instead, ask after docile, tame, and subdued sexualities that may suffer from having *lost their footing* in the perverse.

Adam's vignette provides a framework that will help us investigate how erotic experience may be further quickened by racialization and how perversity can help us imagine audiences "who *don't* want closure, whose readings practices are not fueled by a penetrative, epistemic drive moving always towards 'deeper' levels of meaning" (Doyle, 2013, p. xiii). I propose a set of psychoanalytic tools that offer a vantage point routed through the perverse that shifts the weight of our attention from hounding for causative chains and chasing after meaning to exploring what happens when we allow ourselves to become subject to the force and to the impetus emergent in perversity. That there is potential in perversity is, of course, not a new idea at all; queer theory (Bersani, 1986; Davis & Dean, 2022; Dean, 2008, 2009, 2012; Halperin, 1995; Stockton, 2006) and queer of color critique (Chambers-Letson, 2020; Cruz, 2016; Musser, 2014; Rodríguez, 2014; D. Scott, 2010) have already argued these points convincingly. My Laplanchean approach adds to these conversations by showing *how* some erotic practices build their transformational density, by showing that some types of aesthetic experience have important ties to the perverse, by naming some of the resistances that arise in us in the encounter with the liminal forces of the infantile sexual which turn us away from encountering opacity, and by offering a different approach to perverse pleasures that evades perversion's conceptual fate of being either pathologized or kneecapped by incurious, liberal acceptance.

My hope is to whet an appetite for theorizing the alien and the bizarre in sexuality not from within a state of alarm or from the rubric of tolerance (Jakobsen & Pellegrini, 2004) but by sitting with the *force* of shock that can facilitate (through processes I discuss) an encounter with opacity. "Opacity," Perry Zurn describes, "insists upon a space for curiosity, marked not by clarity but complexity . . . where histories break, and incommensurability cracks open" (2021, p. 206). Even the most progressive and capacious queer thinking can run aground in theorizing the perverse—and nowhere do we hit this impasse with more difficulty or urgency than in the domain of race and racial difference. Consider,

for example, how even as capacious a thinker as the queer theorist José Muñoz strained to make sense of Gary Fisher, a gay Black man whose erotic desires were organized around wanting to be sexually dominated by an older White man. That Fisher's eroticism elided the "anticipatable calculus of equivalence ending in some recognition of the self in the other" (Muñoz, 2019, p. 199) effectively stripped previously relied-on conceptual tools of their explanatory power. "Gary Fisher's writing," Muñoz admits, "is a challenge for those of us who toil in the archives of collective historical dispossession" (2019, p. 197). Fisher's sexual perversity, quickened through the accelerant of racial trauma, becomes thematized in chapter 3. What I want to highlight here is that desires like Fisher's might be easier to navigate if we try to approach them not to "grasp" what motivates them but to respect the inassimilable strangeness of the infantile sexual (what Muñoz calls the "incommensurable"). This directs our attention, instead, to the way perversity's thrust appears phenomenally. Desires that embroil the trauma of the Holocaust in the erotic, as is the case with Liliana Cavani's *The Night Porter*, pose a similar difficulty, waging important conceptual battles about "the future of the past" (Schneider, 2011, p. 4).

While I mostly focus on racial and larger historical traumata, the points I raise can also, with some modifications, be considered for other kinds of trauma. Dorothy Allison, in her autobiographical novel *Bastard out of Carolina* (1992), points us to the way her sexual abuse becomes knitted into her masturbation fantasies and her erotic sensibility. In my classes on psychosexuality, I also read with candidates the anonymously authored *Incest Diary* (2017), a memoir discussing father-daughter sexual incest. Contrary to most such personal accounts, the narrator opens with descriptions of the author's erotic response to her father that are startlingly pornographic, disrupting the genre of memoir-writing on incest. Both these books discuss perverse erotics that cannot be discounted as residual scar tissue without also callously knocking down the ways in which Allison and the anonymous author have fashioned their erotic lives: not by trying to "overcome" trauma but by folding it into their erotic complexion, a traumatophilic approach that we will discuss in depth.

Toward a Theory of Perversity

From a behavioral standpoint, I use the term “perversion” to designate a polymorphous sexual process—rather than circumscribed sex acts—that issue from the materiality of the body, which involve internal experience and which engage, rather than resist, the exigent forces of the infantile sexual. Interembodied, encounters that are experienced as transgressive move toward the “more and more” of experience—and when this escalation becomes unbearable, they can shatter the ego (more on this shortly). Which acts will be experienced as transgressive varies widely: lines of prohibition are perched on the highly personal divide between the intrapsychic, the social, and the historical—that is, who does what to whom, in what context, and at what point in time. And they are also liable to being judged differently based on subject positionality and the degree of privilege accorded them by the socius (Dimen, 2005; Kulick & Rydström, 2015; Srinivasan, 2021). But here I am interested in what is *felt* to be transgressive, because it is that experiential excess that will ultimately contribute to the subject’s feeling overwhelmed enough for anything new to occur: for one, it may be the shame of anal penetration; for another, the longing to be reduced to begging one’s lover; for a third, a forced feminization script. What makes one’s sexuality perverse is not the precise script enacted but the imbrication of transgression with the intensities of the body’s libidinal excitability. The former lures the self into crashing through its own regulatory walls, one’s idiosyncratically sutured line of prohibition, while the latter inundates the subject with indecipherable messages from the other: What does this person want from me? What did that look/gasp/touch mean? (Laplanche calls these “enigmatic,” as we will soon see.)

I am advocating that we accord more serious attention to perversion rather than treating it as an unfairly misunderstood set of nonnormative sexual practices, an approach that too readily forfeits the importance of engaging perversion’s reach. Delving more deeply into such practices can help us sidestep the dipole of perversity as either pathology or benign variation—a concept we find in Freud, who noted “the human need for [sexual] variation” (1905b, p. 151), and in Gayle Rubin, whose plea to acknowledge a wide range of possible sexual appetites in human psychosexuality first put this notion on the queer theory map (1984/2011).³ Ru-

bin's intervention was an admirable, path-clearing effort to carve space for diverse sexual expression, but thirty-five years later, it may now look to us somewhat asthenic—not because its mission has been fully realized (it has not) but because we can now afford to ask more nuanced questions after sexual desires.⁴

Conventionally, we tend to see pleasure and suffering as belonging to ontologically disparate spheres, but Adam's example illustrates that an erotic arc links the two. Psychoanalysis has not fared well when it comes to exploring the coextensiveness of suffering and eroticism, though this snag is not psychoanalysis's problem alone. In *Three Essays*, Freud articulated the sexual as ontologically deviant, considering sadism and masochism as the most important of the perversions.⁵ "As regards active algolagnia, sadism," he wrote, "the roots are easy to detect in the normal [person]"; all sexuality "contains an element of aggressiveness—a desire to subjugate" (1905b, p. 156). Freud, of course, was not unambivalent about the revolutionary nature of his propositions. He thus darts back and forth between the notion that sexuality is definitionally polymorphously perverse and the idea that a postpubertal, mature sexuality will eventually remand the perverse to a sexual sidekick. Provided, says Freud, that one does not linger in foreplay, forgoing "the real thing" (penetrative heterosexual sex), perversion can furnish that "extra" momentum to get you to your real destination, which is none other than orgasm. In (the normative parts of) Freud's developmental theory, therefore, the sexual efflorescence of infantile sexuality (masochism, sadism, scopophilia, exhibitionism, and homoeroticism) becomes compressed into genital and procreative coherence. The terms "developmental theory" and "developmental stages" are, of course, psychoanalytic jargon for normalization: by telling us how things are expected to evolve, they direct the analyst's clinical attention to where intervention is needed.⁶ Freud's wavering notwithstanding, his daringly original insight argued that sadism, masochism, exhibitionism, homosexuality, and even "attraction . . . that overrides the barriers of the species" (1905b, p. 148) are all elements of the sexual.

Has Freud gone too far in this passing reference to bestiality? If so, this is our reminder that for him the perverse really does involve the objectionable and the utterly unthinkable, not just the socially abjected. Even as Freud has given us this list, the question of where we draw the

ethical line, and, most importantly, based on what principles, continues to be up for debate. If the example of bestiality made you uncomfortable, you are not alone. The psychoanalyst Dominique Scarfone helps put some of the complexities of polymorphous perversity in context by clarifying that when it comes to polymorphous perversity, the stress should be placed not on the perverse elements alone but also on the polymorphousness by which the infantile sexual makes itself known to us (2014). For an example of what a polymorphous erotics of bestiality could look like, think of Sophie Lewis's commentary on the Oscar-winning documentary *My Octopus Teacher* (2021). The documentary's protagonist begins to "visit" an octopus, a voyeuristic visitation that vibrates on an erotic frequency with colonial undertones. This voyeurism is awash in perversity; in fact, it is, in some sense, queer because it is so vertiginously perverse.⁷

Still, while Freud's formulation that polymorphous perversity is endemic to our sexual constitution is much cited, it is usually quickly passed over. For the most part, perversion is read as sexuality conscripted into dismal repetitions of the traumatic past (Bach, 1994; Kernberg, 1995; Novick & Novick, 2012) or as the death drive's cooptation of the sexual (Joseph, 1971, 1982; Steiner, 1982). Even analysts who have been thinking more expansively about the multivalent nature of sexual perversions, like Robert Stoller (1975) and Joyce McDougall (1995, 2000), gloss over the fact that sexuality is de facto imbricated in perversity. Treating the interimplication of suffering with pleasure as a failure of the sexual function that requires therapeutic restoration (e.g., Holtzman & Kulish, 2012) leaves out experiences like Adam's. Adam was not self-destructive or reckless, and his experience only enlarged him. Rumbling in the background are sex panics (Rubin, 1984/2011), as well as what Corbett has called the anxiety of regulation (2009): a set of ecstatic anxieties that obtain from the encounter with nonnormativity and that animate the anxious press to regulate the other so as to soothe oneself. Under the aegis of such anxieties, it is easy to get caught in the defensively mobilized quicksand of colonizing the other's sexual particularities by "confus[ing] what the[y] . . . mean to [us] with what the[y] mean" to themselves (Dimen, 2001, p. 833). In the clinical setting, such responses foreclose the analyst's genuine curiosity, blocking important queries into the psychic uses of pleasure that is suffered. In the non-

clinical domain, they can give rise to censorship and shaming or, alternatively, to the patch that is identity and that covers our opacity. One might think that such theories are nowadays mere historical artifacts, relics of a time long gone. But we need only to turn to the way sexuality is regarded today in the larger culture, as something that requires legal fervor and suffocating specificity, and to note the relentless push for an increasingly antiseptic administering of sexuality, to which affirmative consent is stipulated to offer a remedy (Fischell, 2019).

Thinking about perversion is rife with pathologizing discourses. To avoid reflexive pathologization, some authors rely on the relational arrangement within which perversity manifests itself. Perverse sexual relations, some propose, should be considered “normal” when they are mutually enjoyed within the contours of emotionally intimate relationships (Slavin et al., 2004). Similarly, the influential psychoanalyst Otto Kernberg recasts behaviors that are otherwise deemed perverse, such as bondage and domination, into playful sexual adventures as long as they are performed within matrimony’s normativizing confines (1995). For Jessica Benjamin, it is mutuality, equality, and intersubjective recognition that spare polymorphous pleasures from being seen as pathologically perverse. What is wrong with emphasizing equality, you may reasonably wonder. Discourses that stake the permissibility of perverse desires on equity are oblivious to the effects of social asymmetries issuing from racial difference, class disparities, citizenship standing, disability status, and so on. To demand equality as a precondition for sexual variation to be deemed “benign” is to effectively exclude relations between subjects with intersecting minoritarian identities from the captivating affinities between pleasure, pain, and anguish.

These affinities have been heatedly debated in feminist circles, producing political rifts as well as invigorated thinking (Duggan & Hunter, 2006; Hollibaugh, 2000; Lorde, 1982; Rubin, 1984/2011; Vance, 1992; Walker, 1982). And they have also shown that while lessons in good politics can leave us gasping with shame, they do not leave us breathless with arousal (see also Duggan, 2021). Consider, as an example, how many women, straight and queer, entertain rape fantasies or enact play-rape scenes with lovers. Such desires are often interpreted as indexing women having become conscripted into participating in their own violation (e.g., MacKinnon, 2007).⁸ We are still at an impasse as to how to

understand them otherwise. It is that lacuna that makes politically vexed desires vulnerable to the perennial “why” that we cannot stop asking of them. My project looks for another entry point into these debates, one that neither denies the historical and structural circumstances that condition such desires nor surrenders perverse sexual appetites to the cold shower of ethics or good politics. Suffering is often experienced alongside pleasure not only because the material sexual body can become a lightning rod for psychic pain but also because the transgressive blend of flesh and intersubjective engagement can render the pain/pleasure matrix a portal for experience. Again, I am using the word “experience” here not in its ordinary meaning, as in having an experience *of* something as when we take the reins of subjectivity, but as something that we risk when we soften our grasp on those reins, to undergo something the coordinates and effects of which can not be secured or anticipated. When we are talking about pleasure and pain, there is no universal; experience varies widely, and what is aesthetic experience to one person may not be so for others. The ethical is thus not about legislating what is right or wrong, it is about acknowledging that in the erotic domain there are no universals. Experience so defined stands to bring us into contact with our raw being. This is what Adorno called “experimentation”: rather than something we can name, understand, explicate—as Adam and I initially tried to do—such experience throws us off balance.⁹

Attachment Theory, a Normative Theory

To explore why thinking about sexuality alongside trauma is so difficult theoretically, we will need to understand first the ideas that underwrite the presumption that sexuality is about love or about feeling connected and bonded. Two theoretical currents contribute to this: The first, to be explored in chapter 2, has to do with Freud having “go[ne] astray,” as Laplanche describes it (2006b, p. 185), in eventually settling on theorizing sexuality as operating centripetally, that is, as oriented toward linking and organizing. This fastened the erotic to love, to relationality, and to interpersonal connection—that is, to relating to the other as a whole object even though the sexual drive operates according to part-object logics. This move drained sexuality from its more discomfiting and disruptive dimensions. The other theoretical current that

has made it very hard to think about sexuality outside of relationality *per se* has to do with attachment theory, a set of theories that exclusively situate all human functioning, including sexuality, in the quality of the bond developed between the child and their primary caretakers. Situating the sensual lusciousness of the mother-infant dyad at the constitutive epicenter of psychosexual life (Seligman in Slavin et al., 2004), attachment theory argues for sexuality as an expression of relating that privileges connection, deep bonds, and mutuality. This yielded a rather impoverished theory of sexuality in which the mysterious plenitudes of the erotic, not to mention the erotic frisson of power differentials, go limp (see Mitchell, 2003). Unsurprisingly, such mother-infant dyads are heedlessly imagined as White, middle class, cis-gender, and able-bodied, and are usually imagined as nested in a heterosexually organized normative family structure. This blanched-out, homogenized thinking persists despite the fact that its normative strivings have been heavily critiqued both inside and outside psychoanalysis (Davis & Dean, 2022; Dimen, 2001; Edelman, 2004; Eng, 2001, 2010; Eng & Han, 2019; González, 2020).

Desexualizing the parent-infant dyad sidesteps many of the difficulties that arise when visceral eroticism surfaces in relationships of care. More specifically, research shows that while caretakers name and mirror children's affect when it comes to anger or sadness, sexual affects are almost always ignored (Fonagy, 2008; Target, 2007)—the adult looks away, breaks eye contact, refrains from offering language, and so on. This is not mere avoidance (though it is also that); it has to do with the difficulty posed by the sexual. What, after all, asks the psychoanalyst Jody Davies (2001), would be the equivalent response to an empathic registration of a child's sexual arousal that would not amount to sexualizing the relationship? We may say to a child, "you must be sad," mirroring their sadness, but we cannot say, "you must be turned on," and certainly cannot mirror their excitement. Anxieties about how dizzying erotic affect can be also arise in the consulting room as hibernating desires can awaken in the erotic heat of the therapeutic relationship. The same goes for the classroom, where things can also become vertiginously erotic.

Importantly, attachment theory has not been merely a theoretical turn but has become the predominant theoretical paradigm that organizes thinking around the sexual—and not just in psychoanalysis—

though thankfully, within psychoanalysis, some authors have continued to write about the astonishing libidinal power of pleasure. For example, the influential analyst Ruth Stein notes the extraordinary poignancy of sexual experience, giving us an understanding of psychosexuality as always already dysregulated (1998, 2008). Muriel Dimen also has urged analysts to think alongside arousal (1999) and not to recoil from the excitements of disgust (2005) and perversity (2001). Her work queries the analyst's squeamishness, noting the multiple ways in which personal anxieties about the intensities of sexual experience get churned into theoretical formulations that are then elevated to orthodoxy. Even this more expansive thinking about the psychosexual, however, is quick to qualify the "dangers" inherent to sexuality and can see excitement and arousal as swarming with menacing risks. Stein, for example, warns that libidinal thrills may get out of hand, cautioning us as analysts to ensure that our patients' libido not feed on exploitation (2005b). Concerned that the erotic may "deteriorate into obscenity" (2005a, p. 26), Stein emphasizes the importance of working with the patient to regulate the intensities of the patient's sexual passions lest they get out of hand. The normative dangers of such regulation are obvious, but, to list them shortly here, we can easily imagine that some subjects' racialization or gendered embodiment may unevenly "select" them for such regulation and that, similarly, nonnormative desires may also more readily be diagnosed as being dangerously voluptuous and out of control. As for Stein's caution about sexuality becoming exploitative or entailing the other's erasure, I want to call attention to how violation and trauma seem to be the only imaginable possibilities when one treads beyond the well-regulated domain of the sexual. When it comes to the erotic, limits of one sort or another always slip in as critical to the preservation of order. The role of the limit in this context is one of guardianship: to ensure that pleasure will not disband the Law or throw the subject into disarray.¹⁰ Pitting the limit against pleasure, however, overlooks that psychosexuality is amplified through prohibition.¹¹ This lesson, handed down to us by the Marquis de Sade (1795/1966c, 1797/1966a), appears in its more contemporary iterations in the work of Georges Bataille (1957) on transgression. We will turn to that work shortly. But first, we will need a theory of psychosexuality that is less panicked about the intensities of sexual excitement.

Jean Laplanche: *The Fundamental Anthropological Situation*

For Laplanche, the other has a foundational and, in fact, inaugural impact on psychic formation.¹² Critiquing the Ptolemaism dominating analytic thinking, which positioned the self at the center of its own psychic universe (with the sun going round the Earth), he fleshed out a Copernican theory that privileges otherness (1992b). In emphasizing the primacy of the other in the constitution of the unconscious and the ego, he thus shares with Glissant an interest in allocentrism. Here are the main tenets of his theorizing regarding the constitution of the psychic apparatus.

Let us consider a father who, in cleaning his son during a diaper change, applies slightly, but identifiably, less pressure on the infant's anal area.¹³ Why might that be? The short answer is that we do not know. But we could guess: it could be that incest anxiety kicked in or that homoerotic anxiety inhibited him or that he got worried that such touching would be in some way "inappropriate," too sexual, and so on. Whatever the case may be, we see that the adult's attachment-message to the child (e.g., "let me clean you and make you comfortable") was surcharged with something else. This spillover, which "contaminates" the message, as Laplanche described it, issues from the adult's own sexual unconscious, which is awakened through the adult's contact with the child's profound embodied vulnerability. For Laplanche, the adult's exposure to the infant's radical helplessness specifically awakens the adult's perversity (i.e., his sexual unconscious), though it is important to note that Laplanche does not have in mind a disturbed adult but, rather, speaks to the kindling of the normative perversity in all adults. In fact, he considers this unintended and inadvertent "intervention of the other" (Laplanche, 1987, p. 143) on the child so universal that he calls it the "Fundamental Anthropological Situation" (FAS). Returning to the diaper-change scene, the infant senses this surcharge in the adult's message. How? He senses it through the embodied relation, precisely because this surcharge has produced a shift in *how* the father touched his skin (the "identifiably less pressure.") The infant registers this change in a very rudimentary way; the infant senses that "something" happened, but what that something was is unclear to him. It is, in Laplanchean terminology, enigmatic. It is enigmatic not because it represents an in-

tellectual challenge to the child's yet-undeveloped mind (though that is also true) but because, having issued from the father's sexual unconscious in the first place, its meaning is unknown *and unknowable* even to the father, who, as is often the case, may not even be aware that he touched the anus differently.

The infant receives the adult's enigmatic surplus *as* a message, as something *meant to communicate something to him*, even as enigma is not really a message addressed to anyone but a spillover of the parent's unconscious.¹⁴ Enigma, then, functions as an "internal foreign body." Having pierced the child's psychophysiological surface (the skin) through, in this example, the "identifiably less pressure," enigma is a question mark without an answer: What was my father trying to say to me? Why did he touch me differently there? and so on. This process (of enigma's effraction into the infant), which Laplanche called "implantation," is strangely traumatic, and the interference it introduces "must at all costs be mastered and integrated" (2003b, p. 208). Implantation's indelible trauma, to be clear, is not in the order of meaning. That is, the infant is not traumatized because he senses the father's homoeroticism or picks up on the father's incestuous anxiety (remember, it is I who made the hypothesis that the father struggled with that). What the infant is traumatized by is the implantation of something unknowable (enigmatic) in him. Implantation, then, is traumatic because of its indelible *effect* on the infant's psyche. The son in our example is left with this enigmatic implant that is "'stuck' in the envelope of the ego like a splinter in the skin" (Laplanche, 1999, p. 209).

The infant is impelled to make meaning out of these enigmatic implants to cope with the strain of the way the adult's perversity has "broken into" his psychic envelope. Laplanche called this meaning-making process "translation," and it is important to remember that translation is not about "translating" the secret meaning of enigma but about coating its opaqueness with an ascribed meaning. For Scarfone (2016), translation is akin to fantasizing. The ego develops out of the cumulative layerings of these translations, that is, through the aggregate effects of enigma's meaning-filled coatings. As such, the ego is established as an apparatus that constructs meaning (symbols, fantasies, etc.) and that binds (organizes) enigma. Enigma, said differently, is organized into fantasies and representations. I cannot emphasize enough that these

translations are neither correct nor incorrect decodings of the adult's intentions but simply efforts to master the unintelligibility of the adult's communication (Scarfone, 2021). To put it simply, the ego is made up of psychic representations that are more energetically stable (more bound psychic energy), while enigma is energetically charged and, thus, more mobile and less stable (unbound energy). Unbound energy threatens the coherence and stability of the more bound form (the ego, identity), and translation—the binding of unruly energy into more durable forms—is a reduction in intensity that works to reduce that threat. Fantasy and representation, to put it differently, are a form of management.

This self-theorizing is what also distinguishes humans from nonhuman animals: the human subject, writes Laplanche, “is a self-theorizing being . . . humans are self-symbolizing” (1987, p. 14). The notion that our humanity inheres in our capacity to wrest meaning out of trauma, means that humans are not just driven to symbolize but that we *become* human by engaging in the activity of symbolizing. It is our capacity to translate again and again that furnishes our humanity and this, we will see in chapters 3 and 4, has significant implications for thinking about racialization in general and about Blackness in particular.

Translation, Laplanche believed, never quite fully manages to coat enigma with meaning, and, as such, no translation is ever complete: an ineffable, untranslated remainder always remains. These “unworked chunks” (Laplanche, 1992a, p. 12) float inside the infant's psyche. Unbound by the ego, they dwell inside us *on a somatic register* that exceeds psychic organization. “Resistant to all metabolization” (Laplanche, 1999, p. 136), these remainders become repressed (Laplanche called this “primal repression”), which is how the unconscious is formed. Repression congeals these highly charged elements, reifying them into what comes to feel alien and opaque to us about ourselves. This is what Laplanche calls the unconscious, and we see that, for him, repression *creates* (rather than populates) the unconscious. Repressed enigma will continue to press for translation, constituting the sexual drive. The sexual drive will henceforth exert an exciting, compulsive power, a sense of exigency (Laplanche, 2006b). This exigency, I add, both propels and frightens us: following it draws us closer to ourselves but also involves overcoming a gradient of resistance *to ourselves*.

For Laplanche, the unconscious is sexual through and through, and it is synonymous with infantile sexuality.¹⁵ The unconscious and infantile sexuality are, thus, established as fundamentally alien to the self, as persistently and hauntingly other (Laplanche, 1999), always “resistant to straightforward intelligibility” (Davis & Dean, 2022, p. 19). By definition that which we cannot possess, sexuality is never “ours”: it is, rather, the way in which we become “dispossessed through the address of the other” (Butler, 2005, p. 54)—though by “address,” Laplanche does not refer to the other addressing us but to the way in which we respond to the other’s enigmatic intervention by imagining it to address us. If our sexuality is never fully ours, if it is constituted through the inevitable failures of translation, we see that sexuality is not a domain where we may ever have sovereign control or reliable self-understanding.¹⁶ To the contrary, it is a part of ourselves that we can only be drawn closer to, and that drawing closer happens through our opacity. That, as we will see, has considerable implications for thinking about sexual politics and raciosexual trauma. For now, however, let us stay with noticing how a Laplanchean unconscious is ontologically opaque from the outset: not a treasury of repressed memories, fantasies, and affects but an energetically unsubordinated realm that resists the ordering force of the ego.

Memories, fantasies, and affects also get repressed, and that process Laplanche calls “secondary repression.” Secondary repression is what other analysts (and everyday language) mean when we say that something was “repressed”—the removal from consciousness of unbearable memories, traumatic experience, or ideas that are incompatible with the way we view ourselves. For Laplanche, however, secondary repression is secondary in the sense that what it represses has *already* been translated, that is, has already been subjected to some degree of psychic organization. Secondarily repressed material does not get “stored” in the unconscious (remember, the unconscious is of an order that definitionally resists all psychic organization) as fantasies, memories, and the like but in what Laplanche called the “pseudo-unconscious.” The prefix “pseudo-” is not meant to imply falsity of content (repressed memories, fantasies, affects, etc. are always true on the level of psychic reality) but that it is not a truly dynamic, reconfigurable entity. Material that has been repressed secondarily is not part of the unconscious (as a psychic

structure); it is unconscious only in the sense that it is not consciously accessible to us and cannot be called up at will.

There are interesting affinities between Laplanche's notion of the unconscious and Glissant's thinking on opacity. Glissant explains that opacity resists "enclosure within an impenetrable autarchy" (1990, p. 191). Like the unconscious, which cannot be recovered but only coated with meaning, opacity also requires that we "give up this old obsession with discovering what lies at the bottom of natures" (Glissant, 1990, p. 190). Similar to Laplanche, Glissant also stays attendant to what resists capture, as "seizure or grasp is the very thing [he] seeks to undo with his notion of opacity" (León, 2020a, p. 182). Importantly, Glissant understands this desire/urge/impulse to capture as being deeply rooted in the tradition of Western philosophical thought and as giving rise to colonial violence. For Laplanche, the urge to seize and grasp is more rooted in the psyche's need to cope with the dis-order introduced by the intervention of the other's sexual unconscious. So while Glissant and Laplanche share an allocentric focus, they have a different understanding of where the impulse to dominate over the external other comes from. For Glissant, "seizure or grasp" is an appropriative impulse that involves the imposition of a Western framework on other cultures that seek to rapaciously assimilate the foreign into its own systems of thought.

Even though Glissant thinks with coloniality and worldliness and Laplanche stays in the domain of interiority and the self (as the psychoanalytic tradition problematically often does), it is possible to put them in conversation to profitably expand both. What Glissant adds to Laplanchean metapsychology is a way of thinking more critically about psychoanalysis's seemingly benign preoccupation with "understanding" our patients and trying to exhaustively account for the patient's psychic productions.¹⁷ What Laplanche's thinking may add to Glissant's formulation about opacity is that the opaque may not be languid but restless, and that it has a force and an impact that may be specifically energetically sexual. That would situate the opaque in an energetic regime that stands to unsettle the ego's homeostatic hold, helping us understand why opacity "materializes as a resistance" (León, 2020a, p. 172)—to think of opacity both as generating resistance and also as introducing an energetic disquiet that can itself resist established meanings of world-making. Let us bracket this issue for now to loop back to Laplanche.

An especially important aspect of Laplanche's theory is that parental implantations, even when pleasurable—or, I would say, perhaps especially then—involve in their excessiveness the experience of painful shock: “The necessarily traumatic intervention of the other must entail,” he notes, “most often in a minor way but sometimes in a major one—the *effraction or breaking in characteristic of pain*” (1999, p. 123; emphasis added). This space between the parent's enigmatic leak and the infant's translation is necessary for the emergence of the ego, and, thus, of the subject. We see, then, that subject formation originates from the other's enigmatic effraction into us, an effraction that is inevitable (rather than intentional) and that happens without regard for our consent. (There are implications here for thinking about consent which I forgo until chapter 2.) Insofar as the intervention of the other is, per Laplanche, psychosomatically registered as pain, what this means is that implantation welds pleasure with pain: the process, to borrow a phrase from Michel Foucault, both “consumes and consummates us” (1977, p. 44). Sexual excitement originates in this gap between the caretaker's excess and what the infant's ego can bind; the misalignment between the two is riveting. Add to this the bodily sensations that arise later in life through the excitations of the bodily surfaces, and we end up with a veritable powerhouse of experience, at the foundation of which lies the other's trespass into us—a trespass to which we also owe our subjectivation.

When amplified, the literary theorist Leo Bersani proposed, this interimplication of pleasure/pain can leave the subject “momentarily undone” (1986, p. 100). This unraveling of the self “disrupt[s] the ego's coherence and dissolve[s] its boundaries” (Bersani, 1986, p. 101), an experience that Bersani famously described as the self's shattering.¹⁸ Bersani's theoretical move was arresting, dealing a decisive blow to the prized notion, in psychoanalysis and beyond, that psychic life rests on continuity, integration, and synthesis. From a Laplanchean perspective, ego shattering amounts to the ego's links, organized through translation, being broken down. As an unstitching of the meaningful threads that compose the ego, the self's shattering would be akin to what Laplanche called “detranslation,” “a dismantling and a reversal of translation” (1989, p. 413). This is nothing less than a “scouring, a scraping away, of the existing translation” (Laplanche, 1989, p. 415), which is another way of saying that detranslation de-links the chains that the ego forged in craft-

ing its translations and, thus, itself. We could think of detranslating as pulling on a dangling thread left behind when a sweater has snagged: if one keeps going, the sweater will be reduced to mere string. This is a good metaphor for what happens as the ego's breakdown brings down the self, in the undoing of the subject. To appreciate the implications of detranslation and ego shattering, we will want to examine more closely the processes by which the ego is formed. This will help us understand better Laplanche's claim that detranslation can turn us "toward the *past*" to attempt "a better translation—one more inclusive, less repressive, with new possibilities" (1989, p. 420).

Translation: Ego, Mastery, Power

The question of how the infant forges her translations is an important one for Laplanche—and for my thinking in this book. Since there are no "real" meanings to be recovered, the infant must seek codes with which to organize the ways she will make sense of enigma. The infant "doesn't invent these from nothing" (Laplanche, 2003b, p. 216), but uses what is already available to her: her experience of her body (e.g., the experience of inside-outside) and what is made available to her from the domain of the mythosymbolic. The mythosymbolic includes significations that circulate in the larger social milieu and the familial environment: these are meaning-making templates that have to do with myths, symbols, and stories. These exist in the "adult cultural world in which the infant is completely immersed from the outset" (Laplanche, 1984, p. 303), and they permeate the parents' embodied lives, which means that they are conveyed to the child both verbally and nonverbally. "Codes, knowledges, languages, and structures of feeling," Teresa de Lauretis explains (2017, p. 1921), all get called into this process of translation, and they all participate in making the production of the ego.

The infant, however, does not just passively introject the mythosymbolic. Picking up elements of this and that, she combines these elements inventively and of her own accord, which means that our translations are assembled by each of us idiomatically. The word "assembled" may give a false impression, as if this were a conscious, deliberate process, which it is not; what I am trying to highlight, rather, is that there is some range in how the mythosymbolic may be put to use by each of us to yield

our ego and our translations. As a result, even though the ego that gets churned out of this process is threaded together through “found objects” that are not of our creation, because it arises through personal innovation, it comes to feel *genuinely ours*, not what others think about the way the world works but *our own knowledge* of the way the world works. Translation, that is, gives us our fine-grained individuality. Laplanche specifically addresses gender as such a meaning-making template. As a cultural object that is readily made available to parents and the larger family circle and that appears as simply “natural,” binary gender circulates in the mythosymbolic as a tool with which to tame the enigmatic excess of the parents’ communications.¹⁹ Others have extended this thinking to race, to argue that enigmatic signifiers “colonize the unconscious” (Evzonas, 2020).

If translation rests on existing mythosymbolic codes, what this would also mean is that all the problematic elements in the concept of race (and any other social category, really, that may be used as a translational tool) will also infiltrate the ego’s translational efforts. These problematic elements, therefore, play a role in ego formation. This would connect processes of racialization to translation, thereby situating “race” and racism as part of the ego, which, we will recall, Freud described as being primarily bodily (1923). As such, dominant ideologies and prevalent understandings of the world and how it works, as well as the troubling assumptions baked through them (prejudices, preoccupations, stereotypes, symbolic conflations, and so on), which subtend the categories of race (and gender), would also participate in the ego’s formation.

For example, let us imagine a Black mother sitting in a pediatrician’s waiting room with other mothers, most of them White. Let us also imagine that her infant, exploring the space, crawls toward a White person’s belongings. The mother may quickly pick the child up, urging him to stay closer. This urging may be about him respecting others’ private space, but it could also be about the mother’s concern about how White people would respond to her child’s approach. Such communication conveys to the child much more powerfully than words ever could that there is something about him (the infant) nearing White people’s belongings that may become difficult, even dangerous. Even as race may not enter the mother’s verbal communication per se, her intervention is awash in the mythosymbolic register. That is, the mother is function-

ing aware of race and racism and the ways both are affected by gender. She may have particular concerns due to racist stereotypes of Black masculinity and the way they shape how the world perceives her son. The mother's communication to the child has messages about race and racism in it, but it is not enigmatic in the Laplanchean sense because even though it is nonverbal, it is still based on some organized "code[], knowledge[], language [and] structure[] of feeling" (de Lauretis, 2017, p. 1921) that circulates in the mythosymbolic space (i.e., about how White people respond to Black bodies), of which the mother probably has personal experience. The meanings conveyed implicitly to the infant become available as translational tools, and they include a web of symbols and myths about race and gender, myths about safety and dangerousness, about racial difference and the perils of interracial encounters, and so on. The infant may use these to format his own sense of his racialization and to forge a sense of the raced world around him: the problematic myths about race, then, will also form part of his ego.

The implications for thinking about translation in the social world are that the prevailing systems that organize the adult world—and that are permeated by patriarchy, ableism, racism, heterosexism, normative gender ideology, and so on—also become part of the ego's cohering glue, getting swirled into our very sense of self from the get-go. I purposefully use the word "swirled" to underscore that these problematic ideas do not layer themselves atop an otherwise pristine, unbiased subject. This means that they cannot be simply removed from the rest of the self as if peeling back an outermost, tainted layer of soiled film, as is imagined by discourses that urge us to "become aware" of unconscious racism, tend to sexist presumptions, mind heterosexist prisms, check one's privilege, etc. Because the ego is largely oriented toward protecting its integrity and cohesion by inhibiting the disturbance that change ushers into it, and because many of these defensive operations happen outside our awareness or, at least, without our conscious control, becoming, say, more educated about one's privilege or learning to better discern White-supremacist logics will only touch the more logical, outermost layers of the self, leaving untouched the more visceral inscriptions. Education, in the sense of knowing the history surrounding these oppressions and being able to "read" where and how they are ongoing, is important; but such interventions, while important, do not penetrate the deeper levels

of psychic structure. Tragically, these “-isms” are not pollutants of an otherwise pure psyche but the very materials through which one’s sense of self is constituted—for both majoritarian and minoritarian subjects. They are baked into how we are subjectivized.

Of course, the specific contents of these elementary translational building blocks vary from culture to culture—and from subculture to subculture—across chronological epochs, and from one family (whatever its kinship structure) to another. In other words, the concept of racial difference does not circulate in different adult worlds (from which the infant will pluck for their translational efforts) in the same ways or with the same meanings. But the point I want to make is that because the translations become the basic units out of which our sense of self coagulates, whatever -isms and biases saturate the cultural surround may become baked into *who we become*. Counterintuitively, then, all subjects, even those who inhabit intersecting minoritarian identities, like the infant in the pediatrician’s waiting room in our example earlier, may develop ego structures that are, to some degree, organized through ideas (in this case, about race and racism) that serve dominant ideologies.

Putting Glissant’s insights side by side with Laplanche, then, we could say that the ego is, to a certain degree, if not coextensive with power structures, at least sometimes working on a colonial, appropriative logic. “Assimilation, appropriation, aggression, infantilization, or emasculation—all the psychical strategies commonly associated with racism,” Homay King explains, could be seen through Laplanche’s theory as “driven by the desire to eradicate or bind the *internal* otherness, implanted in the form of the enigmatic signifier and revived by an encounter with an other” (2010, p. 32). But we need to remember that the agent responsible for conflating the concrete external other (that is, the other human being) with this perturbing internal foreign body in ourselves is none other than the ego itself. In other words, this conflation is not ontological—and, thus, is neither fixed nor immutable. And this conflation is also not something good politics or intentions can eradicate, at least not on the psychic level. “Not so easily segregated,” writes King, “their eradication would be tantamount to the destruction of the self” (2010, p. 32).

I hope that this theorizing, which will be revisited throughout this book from different angles, begins to convey the high stakes accompanying the ego’s undoing—and why its detranslation can have such in-

credible personal and political ramifications. Understanding itself as the sovereign, the ego will dedicate all of its energies to resist contestations of its sovereignty. This is why contact with the sexual unconscious and with opacity is threatening. To preempt this, the ego can produce varied narcissistic crises, some of which may be more “dramatic” (think White fragility and White tears), or more emboldened—and institutionally supported—pushbacks (think of the war waged against critical race theory and trans children), or genuine mental health emergencies (think of a man who becomes suicidal when his sexually harassing behavior becomes public) and so on.

The psychoanalyst Dominique Scarfone describes the ego’s efforts to transduce the disquieting energies of the “internal foreign object” to a more tranquil regime as a reach for mastery (2021, in press). That this attempt will always “egregiously fail” (Scarfone, 2021) does not discourage the ego, which remains dedicated to trying to churn meaning out of the enigmatic and to wrest transparency from opacity. What this means is that binding is also about making the other predictable, never surprising, never a source of curiosity or excitation. (Stereotypes, for instance, do a lot of work in this regard.) The ego’s energies are organized toward binding the strangeness of the enigmatic and thus dissipating the alterity in oneself and in the other (where it arrives by projection). But translation, thankfully, cannot achieve complete mastery over extraneous elements of our own and the other’s alterity; both besiege us. In a subject with an engorged sense of narcissism, this failure can feel so humiliating and wounding that mastery transmutes to a drive to power and control of the other (Scarfone, 2021). Social positionality, group membership, and cultural capital can also embolden one—and procure the resources with which—to act over others in destructive ways. So, while the drive to mastery is universal, its mutation into a drive to power is contingent.

The ego resists the energetic turbulences of the sexual. The notion that we are shattered not only in infancy but, if we are lucky, again and again and again paves the way to our being able to think about traumatophilia—that is, our attraction to the site of the traumatic. A return to the site of our constitutive trauma can thus be understood not as a rote and mechanical recursion that is too hackneyed to escape iteration but as a way of touching inaugural wounds, opening up new possibilities. In Adam’s experience, suffering and pleasure amalgamated

to blow him up “into thousands of tiny pieces . . . hanging out in space like overheated pieces of dust.” We may now understand that moment as having to do with how the rise in excitement arising out of Adam’s visceral revulsion and erotic enthrallment overrode his ego’s organized surfaces, rupturing it. Such shatterings may sound traumatic, but they are not necessarily so.

Thinking With, Not Against, Pain

To explore further the kinds of experience that may enable the self’s dissolution, we have to be able to bear thinking *with* pain and abjection. To accomplish this, I turn to ideas from French philosophy, specifically to the notion of “limit experience.” The roots of this concept originate in the eighteenth-century pornographic, eschatological, and philosophical work of the Marquis de Sade and were subsequently elaborated in the philosophies of Bataille, Blanchot, and Foucault.

The Marquis de Sade lived and wrote during the period of the French Revolution. Imprisoned and confined in psychiatric institutions for most of his adult life, he acquired his reputation for writing books of sexually sadistic and masochistic content that he mostly wrote from jail, sometimes on toilet paper, shielding them from his censors by hiding them in cracks on the walls of his cell.²⁰ Much scholarship has proliferated around his pornographic writings, wherein libertines, in the pauses between their debauches, deliver long philosophical treatises on state power, human nature, sovereignty, erotic subjectivity, and the subject-object relation. These philosophical musings, and their implications for political theory, have been densely theorized (Bataille, 1973; de Beauvoir, 1953; Klossowski, 1967; Lacan, 1963/1989; Lévy, 1966; Hénaff, 1999; Phillips, 2001). Sade’s oeuvre captured philosophers’ and political theorists’ attention because of the meticulous attention he paid to how political institutions (e.g., the French aristocracy in its excesses and debauchery and the church) at once defined the limit and invited its transgression. Deeply affected by and inspired by Sade’s work, Bataille posited that the possibility for a very particular kind of experience lies at the transgression of the limit: inner experience.²¹ For Bataille, the limit marks the line between life and death, a death that we deny and the reality of which we refuse to confront—though by death, he did not (only) mean the

end to organic life but a return to uninterrupted being. In his thinking, the limit and its transgression are also connected to the taboo. For him, the institution of taboo, credited as the beginning of civilization, in fact led to the loss of our base humanity, disconnecting us from our animal nature, throwing us in the machine of capitalist production. For Bataille, transgression is thus also a political gesture.²² By bringing us into contact with the base and the abject, it ecstatically erupts back into our humanity, where energy is not conserved in the name of a capitalist future that needs preserving but is, instead, extravagantly wasted in the present. In his writings, he sought to reinstate the central importance of a “general economy” of expenditure (*dépense*), waste, excess, and base materialism to offer a critical response to the focus on scarcity (and its remediation through accumulation), associated with the “restricted economy” of local capitalism. As such, what compels Bataille’s attention are human activities (sacrifice, festival, eroticism) that cannot be rationalized as productive and that offer no functional or utilitarian value. Because eroticism is economically wasteful (aka nonproductive), it is well positioned to disrupt the subject’s continuity and claim present time, wrenching the subject from herself to hurl her toward such an uninterrupted state. Bataille’s contemporary, Maurice Blanchot (1969) described such experiences as what one encounters when one has “decided to put [one]self radically in question” (1969, p. 203).

Foucault was profoundly influenced by his encounter with the works of Sade and Bataille. He theorized experiences of the edge as trying “to reach that point in life which lies as close as possible to the impossibility of living” (Foucault, 1991, p. 31), a “wrenching the subject from itself . . . bringing it to his annihilation or dissolution” (Foucault, 2000a, p. 241). Sexuality, he thought, is in a privileged position to elicit the subject’s tear from herself because, even though bodies are constituted through discourse, they also exceed it (Foucault, 1991).

Not all sexuality is created equal in that regard: the perversity inherent in the sexual makes sexuality that runs on the energetic charge of infantile perversity (as opposed to sexuality that is more tame) ideally suited to bid the ego’s unraveling. Transgression’s insatiable appetite for intensified stimulation can produce paroxysms that override homeostatic controls, thus contesting the ego’s sovereignty. Key to transgressive pleasure is not tension reduction but “the *pursuit of excitation* even to the point

of exhaustion” (Laplanche, 2000b, p. 41, emphasis in original)—a luxuriously wasteful and unproductive consumption of energy. This welling up produces pleasure that is suffered unproductively (expenditure), and it is what furnishes perversity with its queer and anarchic potential. Courting the limit is not about triumphing over boundaries or intending to shock or to omnipotently triumph over limits (Nigro, 2005)—such triumphing, after all, would be about mastering (binding) when at stake is the ego’s contestation (unbinding). This is important because the ego’s contestation has ties to opacity, whereas narcissistic triumph is about the refusal that there is anything outside the ego’s reign. If the practices that are more conducive to limit work are scandalous or subversive, this is not for the sake of shock per se but because their exuberant energies are more likely to kindle the escalating economy of the sexual drive.²³ We should heed Tim Dean’s caution that “simply accept[ing] or, indeed, celebrat[ing] perverse sexuality” by folding it into an ego/identity structure may itself “be a way of avoiding what is so intransigently difficult about [perversion]” (2014, p. 269).

Rather than the homeostatic regulation that attachment theory idolizes (Lyons-Ruth, 1999, 2006), this vigorous pursuit of experience pushes past the limit to become overwhelming, threatening the ego’s integrity. Although when we speak of sexuality, we refer to a set of representations and/or to conduct relating to sex, the erotic is always infiltrated by the sexual drive, by the more rogue, unintegrated, radical root of the infantile sexual. Importantly, varied kinds of experiences can be arrogated by the infantile sexual, including art. Activities annexed by the drive’s perversity may thus bring the subject against her limit—and this is more amplified with practices that have an energetic affinity with the infantile sexual: the erotic, repetition, and trauma are especially apposite for such experiences. When such energetic extravagance overruns homeostatic controls, the ego can become unmoored and break open, to hurl the subject into a state of uninterrupted belonging (Bataille, 1957).²⁴

Instead of focusing on identifying and maintaining optimal levels of stimulation that protect the subject from being overwhelmed or arguing for relying on the other as a way of ensuring that injury and trauma are avoided, this volume asks after eroticism and performance that flows not away from but *toward* overstimulation. Therein, in what I call the “more and more” of experience, in experience that presses into the unbearable,

a state of “overwhelm” may arise. What is often read as compulsiveness in repeated enactments of perverse sexual scripts (Bach, 1994) and what Freud (1905b) thought of as the quality of “fixity” in perversion can, instead, be seen as a path to the ego’s unraveling. This unraveling may, in turn, bring down previously established meanings in favor of new ones that might replace them. To think of perversity this way is to grant it considerably more psychic heft than implied in the concept of “benign variation,” without seesawing into pathologizing perversion.

Interembodied sexual experience that is powered by transgression’s search for escalating excitations has the extraordinary potential to recapitulate the scene of implantation, that is, to undo the links between enigma and its translations. This breaking open of the ego will animate the ego toward new translating work. In the following chapters, we will encounter how experiences that usher such ego ruptures are subtended by an unusual type of consent that is not of the affirmative kind and that has more to do with making oneself susceptible to something unknown and unpredictably opaque in oneself. But let us now briefly loop back to Adam.

Adam

Recalling Adam’s experience of feeling like overheated bits of dust, we can now see that moment as the phenomenological correlate of ego shattering. Adam was disrupted in encountering the abject in himself and in experiencing the desire that was “opened up” in his body by his repulsive stranger. What occurred after that was not an explosion of unbridled energy that got out of hand. Adam did not dissociate; he did not have a psychotic break; nor was he traumatized. Trying to approximate what happened for Adam, we might say that he was in an altered state of consciousness (Ghent, 1990; Epstein, 2004), a state of heightened attention whereby he experienced an unusual sense of presence, a fleeting state of self-sovereignty.²⁵

Exploring this state in Adam’s analysis suggested that the moment of unraveling behaved like a portal. Incomprehensible fragments of experience leaped forward—Adam’s semi-hallucinated black object, the reverberating sound, the jolting skin sensation he could not place entered the analytic space. These were not objects to be dissected for meaning.

Rather than vivisect, to cut them open in the hope of discovering some hidden truth, and thus killing off their vitality, we followed their intensities.²⁶ Instead of asking what messages might have become encysted in the sound that was neither voice nor cry, whether the “fuzzy black object” pointed to an entombed memory, whether the jolting sensation was a faint mnemonic trace, which would treat them as something to master, we came to appreciate that his sexual encounter had somehow rendered the ineffable into something that appeared in the world. Becoming something that could be apprehended by him in the moment and by us in the session, the enigmatic thus came to have the effect of presence.²⁷

With time, Adam and I relaxed our grip on trying to grasp these appearances and gave ourselves over to the emerging realization that we would have to work *with* this opacity rather than against it (i.e., trying to make it transparent). With this implicit admission came something else: new associative chains began to form between these sensory experiences and parts of Adam’s history that wrenched our attention from its previously habituated focus. Stories that I had never heard before began to emerge, and others that had been repeated lifelessly for months began to stir with life. Something new and enlivening was happening.

Toward a Theory of Traumatophilia

La Negresse

Term for rear-entry intercourse in Alex Comfort's *Joy of Sex* (1972)

Coined for the curved mountain of our backsides,
front legs table top collapsed,

the term is French because we're foreign
(women's desires impolite English),

the term pejorative because I want
my crêpe-paper, lily-white-secretion maker

trifled with. Worse than *doggy-style*,
the conflation of animals and deep penetration,

la negresse implies only black women like it
-my ass in tuned vibrato-

or are the only ones willing to admit it.
Mostly, though, I want to know

if that's how you liked it, Sally,
if Paris made you

in its manner of blackness.
—Chet'la Seabee, *Mistress*

In this chapter, I pick up where I left off at the end of chapter 3 so that I may reflect more deeply on the concept of traumatophilia. I have been exploring the somewhat counterintuitive proposition that we may be overly focused on what can be done *about* trauma, suggesting instead that we slacken our grip on the therapeutics of trauma to allow ourselves to become more interested in what subjects do *with* their trauma.

I introduced the term “traumatophobic” to capture the former approach and the term “traumatophilic” for the latter, purposefully choosing the suffixes “-phobic” and “-philic” to pack into these terms a shorthand that respectively conveys the repellent effects of fear and the attractive forces of affinity.

Deepening our exploration of traumatophilia will involve developing greater conceptual elasticity for thinking about repetition: what it is, what it does, what it looks like, and how it can feel. As we saw in chapter 3, repetition is not necessarily destructive but, when laced with pleasure, can be transformative, even conducive to expanded psychic freedoms. In this chapter, I offer further conceptual tools from psychoanalysis to convey what such repetitions look like (extravagant and superfluous) and what they can feel like (anguishing and magnetizing). My hope is to demonstrate that repetition deserves our trust and, also, our commitment. To flesh out these ideas, I return to *Slave Play* but now from the angle of my own repeated viewings of the play, to discuss what my bizarre and perversely iterative relationship to the play did to, and for, me. I take myself as a case study to probe how traumatisms may come to repeat toward sovereign experience. Focusing in particular on the play’s third act and the various controversies the play generated, I offer reflections on how giving oneself over to repetition, though arduous and anguishing, is related to undergoing aesthetic experience. In this chapter, it is not just ideas about repetition but also the *action* of repetition that is at work. Put more strongly, repetition is not only the theme but also the method of this chapter.

The chapter concludes with an examination of the documentary *The Artist and the Pervert*, which narrates the relationship between Mollena Williams-Haas, the Black woman we encountered earlier as Williams (her pre-married name), a prominent sex educator and an artist, and her husband, Georg Friedrich Haas, an Austrian-born, White man and prominent composer. To be clear, I am not analyzing their individual psychologies; rather, I offer the example to stretch our thinking about what being drawn to the touching of wounds can look like. The example of Williams-Haas and Haas shows what may arise when two individuals step into the fray of traumatophilia together. This exploration fortifies the bid I make in this book: for us to orient the resources of our critical attention toward the permutations in which trauma re-appears (traumatophilia) rather than remaining focused on trauma’s repair, that is,

on how to make trauma dis-appear (traumatophobia).¹ Traumatophilia does not dismiss the negative effects suffered by traumatized persons. Rather, recognizing that trauma both disrupts *and* shapes us (Saketopoulou, 2014), traumatophilia puts pressure on the all-too-human impulse to overpromise the reversing of injury and moves us away from the instrumentality of cure. “Cure cannot be taken as the aim of psychoanalysis,” writes Laplanche, “‘cure’ is no more relevant an aim than divorce. Both imply the social adaptation of the profession. . . . Psychoanalysis has to put all socially-adaptive aims—that is, the whole notion of self-preservation—in brackets” (1992a, p. 6). The task of psychoanalysis is “to keep the injury of the other open” (Laplanche, 1999, p. 241), to “reopen[] the wound of the unexpected” (p. 280).

My concern about “cure” is not just that it can easily be routed toward supporting the existing social order, turning the consulting room into a Procrustean bed of normative adaptation. Even more importantly, I believe healing is unrealistically overpromised, sending us and the patients we treat on a wild goose chase. As a practicing psychoanalyst, I would say that trauma is never cured and that no one has ever been delivered back to an intact, pretraumatic state, no matter how motivated they are or how good their access to care or their resources. This is a statement that many clinicians would agree with in theory. But when the rubber hits the road, that is, when we sit with patients who need help, many of us, just like many of our patients, get caught in the quicksand of imagining that psychoanalysis or therapy can restore mental health, that it can help repair and, in some way, undo wounds. This belief prevails outside the clinic as well: both popular culture and academic discourse like to imagine subjects whose injuries (personal or structural) may be worked through, ridding the subject of their imprint. At best, though, we learn to live in trauma’s afterlife, and I say this not to imply that political struggles for betterment should be therefore abdicated or that we should give in to social injustices, but because I am concerned about the burgeoning neoliberal economies that promise impossible healing and worry about the seductive assurances of contemporary medicine-men who tell us we can overcome pain.² I am equally concerned with the renaissance of individualism that is insidiously smuggled even into social movements that seek liberation, enticing us with alluring fantasies of mastering pain and of a resolute draining of the traumatic past.

But wounds never fully close. They leave behind marks and scabs that can reopen and that *we are strangely drawn to touch*. To touch them, we must first reopen them, which involves cracking open their encasements that, as discussed in chapter 3, are crafted through the primary violence of the mythosymbolic. This touching of wounds involves the revisitation of trauma. It is through repetition that the touching of wounds can acquire the psychic density of traumatizations that, escalating to overwhelm, can invigorate new translational activity. Part of what makes a traumatophilic touching of wounds so impactful is that it can enable immobilized trauma to be put back into circulation. By “immobilized trauma,” I refer to trauma that has been fully narrativized, whose meanings are rigidly affixed, making it impervious to fugitive possibilities. Fugitivity, for Moten, “is a desire for and a spirit of escape and transgression of the proper and the proposed . . . a desire for the . . . outlaw edge proper to the now” (2018, p. 131). Moten is describing openings to uncharted forms of newness. Psychoanalytically speaking, newness involves *renewing*, the calling forth of something old that may be revised. Such revivification, Laplanche writes, “is not trauma but seduction” (1994/2014, p. 31), which is another way of saying that traumatophilia may look like retraumatization—in fact, it often does—but what it stands to do is reopen enigma. Such reopening kindles the psychic irritant of untranslated enigmatic remnants, turning the irritant into a muse that can inspire new translational movements. Said differently, the disquiet of enigma has ties to inspiration and to enlivenment but only as long as the “subject can stay open to the trauma *by means of the trauma*” (1994/2014, p. 33). Instead of repair, a traumatophilic lens is interested in the way trauma is not purged but lived through, though on different terms from those that originally inflicted the injury. Through this reanimating, the visitation of trauma may become an ever-renewable source of inspiration, acting on us in potentially transforming ways.

Importantly, because we become subjectivized through implantative trauma, there is no intactness in our being to begin with to which we may ever be restored, which is another way of saying that we can never be cured of our unconscious. If we start out always already compromised by the intervention of the other’s sexual unconscious into us, trauma is constitutive of our very ontology, not a piece of shrapnel to be removed. Important lineages of thought, starting with Fanon (1952, 1961), running

through Spillers's work on flesh (1987), Hartman's thinking on racial subjection (1997), Patterson's ideas around social death (1982), Sexton's interventions on Black negativity (Barber, 2017), and more recent interventions made by Afropessimism (Wilderson, 2020), point to the way violence and trauma are foundational to the subjectivation of the Black subject in particular. The idea that implantative trauma is constitutive and part of the human condition overall, that it cuts through all humans independently of their racialization, does not deny the specificity of Black suffering and the particular historical conditions that have traumatized, and continue to traumatize, Black people en masse. Nor does it overlook that neo-Jim Crow continues to shape Black subjectivation to this day. Rather, what it highlights is that the argument that these violences have inscribed Blackness outside the category of the human is premised on a very particular understanding of the category of the human. Said differently, ontological negation is not the particular province of Black subjects.

The version of psychoanalysis I am working with is premised on the idea that ontological negation is, *part of our very humanity*. And yet the social order provides all sorts of sutures to White subjects such that White people may not have to confront their always already traumatic ontological status. This allows most White people to proceed with life as if their subjecthood is intact, obscuring that the social privileges of Whiteness expeditiously patch over fissures and gaps, permitting them to experience themselves as unbroken and as deserving to remain unbreakable. White dominance ensures that compensations are always on hand to support this fiction, amounting to a mythology of Whiteness that is so robustly subtended by the formidable structures of White supremacy that it comes to appear natural to all subjects independent of their racialization. This is another way of saying that Whiteness's ideological function is to naturalize the suturing of the traumatically constitutive condition that befalls all humans, projecting it onto Blackness, where it appears as ontological negation. The refusal to acknowledge that opacity lies at the heart of what it means to be human and the resistance to accepting that not everything can be mastered (Laplanche, 2003b; Scarfone, 2021) or grasped (Glissant, 1990; León, 2020a) is what gives Whiteness its density. Part of the rage that some White people experience when faced with enlarged social freedoms and equities for

people of color may be understood from this angle: when inequality gaps narrow, there is a chipping away at some of these social compensations, in turn unveiling the stitchings that the social has installed to support the ideology of Whiteness's ostensible intactness.

Breathless Excitement

Two years ago, I was ravished by Jeremy O. Harris's theatrical work *Slave Play*.

Describing my experience this way may sound melodramatic. But my language is intentional, meant to do more than amplify how much I liked this play or felt changed by it—though both are also true. What took me over was far wilder and infinitely more bizarre: it felt absolutely exigent. The first time I saw this play I felt my whole being called to attention, rousing my senses in a way that no work of art ever has. From there on out, I was overcome with a fiery desire: to experience the play again and again. All I knew was that I wanted more. Interests that normally held my attention were overshadowed, everything else simply felt dampened. What followed was a long period that I can only describe as a possession, as if I had been taken over by a strange force. Repeatedly attending performances felt more like a path I had to follow than a decision. Only in retrospect did I connect this feeling of being possessed to Freud's description of repetition as a demonic force, or link it to the play's third act, which is titled "Exorcism." What exactly the "it" to be exorcised is—and whether that "it" can be exorcised (which, I will argue, is a traumatophobic approach) or merely brought into presence so that one may make contact with it (which I see as traumatophilic) is the main theme explored in this chapter.

Strangely, the experience also felt liberating, though what I was feeling liberated from I could not tell you. I became preoccupied with reading and rereading the script, with thinking and rethinking the dialogue. Week after week I attended Sunday discussions organized by the play's production. I went enthusiastically and enjoyed them immensely. But I was soon also quite chagrined to realize that I could not *not* go. Even as professional obligations and deadlines pressed for my time, I nonetheless found myself regularly heading out for these Sunday salons, eager yet also helpless to resist them.

I was fascinated but also scared by this play *and by my own reactions to it*. In retrospect, I was drawn to it like one who, standing over a cliff, looks down and, feeling an inexplicable draw, steps back. Only I did not take a step back: I stepped into the vertigo. For a year and a half, I watched the play again and again and again. I watched it alone, and I watched it with others. I went at planned times and I also went impulsively, as if seized by a grotesque longing. I once headed to the matinee right after the Sunday salon because the discussion stirred in me a need to experience the play right away. Over time and one repetition after another, I started observing small differences in the way the actors enunciated their lines, the way their bodies' affective charge shifted across performances, the way different audiences laughed (or did not) at certain lines. I talked about the play incessantly to anyone who was willing to listen. I followed Jeremy O. Harris around New York City to hear him talk about the play. Friends forwarded me announcements about talks, interviews, and podcasts about the play, enabling my preoccupation.

Becoming so infatuated with a work of art is not an experience I had had before. It was dazzlingly intense: I felt fiercely alive and throbbingly present. And it was also dizzyingly burdensome: I found the "demands" of my interest confusing, exhausting, and, at times, even terrifying. That only further drew me in. In retrospect, I would say I followed the play the way one follows around a lover before one's first heartbreak, before, that is, one learns to hold some things back. This particular response was, of course, specific to me. I have given much thought to what kept me so engaged, though I should say that I am far from being the only person whose involvement with this play grew unusually intense. *Slave Play* went on to earn a record number of twelve Tony nominations. It received rave reviews as well as unusually lacerating critique, including petitions to shut it down.³ More than its reception though, it is the impassioned way in which theatergoers loved or hated it that I want to emphasize. At the Sunday salons, I met several others of varied racial backgrounds who were also attending the play frequently. Since then, friends, colleagues, and Twitter have made me aware of many others also magnetically drawn to it, returning to the performances again and again. From the perspective of fan studies, it might look like we were constituting a nascent (and irrationally intense) fandom (Booth, 2018; Hills, 2015), but the word "fandom" trivializes the urgency and zeal that swept

over me. The difference is in the quality of the repetition: the return of the “fan” may not be the same as the return of a person who is having the kind of aesthetic experience I am describing, where one revisits not to affirm what one already knows but to be exposed to something at the limits of her understanding.

My dramatic experience with *Slave Play* continues to intrigue me. And it has led to much introspection that, early on, took a form I now see as somewhat naïve and that focused on how my own positionality—as a White, queer, immigrant woman who partly grew up in the former British colony of Cyprus—relates to how engrossing I found it and why. It took me some time to be able to distinguish between my experience of the play and my process of thinking and talking about it, the latter being more about how the play took residence inside me and how that manifested itself outwardly. Thinking and writing *about* the play have involved the conversion of the aesthetic experience I had, which decentered me, into a recentered one that can be tracked and narrated. What was most precious to me about *Slave Play* is failed by words (though, in this chapter, I will try): it was about wonderment and a rousing of an energy in me that is beyond my reach—not a yet-unreached understanding but an *unreachable* one.

When the play’s first Broadway run was ending, I attended the closing performance to bid the play farewell. Leaving the theater that night, I felt bereft. I eagerly awaited a future production. When the pandemic hit, making travel unsafe and closing theaters across the country, it became clear that I would be unable to attend a forthcoming production that was scheduled to open in Los Angeles in the spring of 2020. I felt the cost of this loss acutely—and that itself felt bizarre. To the time of this writing, I continue to think about the play regularly, which is another way of saying that I have established a thinking relation with it in its absence that permits me the luxury of ongoing contact. Turning *Slave Play* into an object of contemplation has transformed it into something that I can hold onto and recall. Of course, the gap between the memory and the experience itself is unbridgeable, and that is itself an experience that I have learned to savor.

Strangely and despite the compulsively iterative and, at times, torturous quality of my relationship to *Slave Play*, this irresistible press did not

impair me—and that still surprises me. I developed a strange, meditative curiosity about my experience and was able to continue seeing my patients, teach, supervise clinical work, run my study groups, and publish. Unsurprisingly, my torrential affair with *Slave Play* imprints itself on my writing and teaching: for example, the script now appears in my syllabi for courses on psychosexuality that I teach to psychoanalytic trainees. I am not mentioning this productivity to extoll the play's fruitful impact on me—as you will see, I am moving in a very different direction than simply professing the play's “usefulness”—but because I am genuinely surprised that my taxing need to experience the play again and again did not compromise me.

When I was under the play's spell, *I had an experience*—not an experience of something but what I can only, and inexactly, describe as pure experience. There were moments when I was singularly focused, acutely present. And despite the general disorienting state I just described, I felt overflowing with life. I am often asked why I kept going back. The question is usually asked of me as a White person—and not, for example, as a Cypriot postcolonial subject who is kept revisiting a play depicting a British man encountering himself in the mirror, and vomiting; or as a queer woman who returned to luscious depictions of queer desire; or, as a woman who went back to watch a rape/not-rape scene again and again. I do not know how to answer that question on the level it is asked without recycling tropes about what we (already think we) understand about racialization. What feels most honest of an answer, though, is that what I was so fervently chasing after in my iterative viewings of *Slave Play* was precisely this state that I described earlier as pure experience—an experience that went far beyond my various positionalities.

I mention in detail my intensely consuming preoccupation with this theatrical piece so that I may query the mechanisms and processes by which this play in particular, and aesthetic experience and performance more generally, may illuminate the workings of repetition and the subject's undoing. Where I thematize my changed relationship to my racialization, I do it not because my personal change per se is relevant to my arguments but because *the fact* that something changed in me is central to my analysis of the way performance can have the transformational impact claimed on its behalf. In other words, my personal growth comes

into this chapter only as a way of concretely illustrating the force with which some performance can act *on* us, how it can evoke states of overwhelm, what performance has to do with the sexual drive, and with the kind of sadism *Slave Play* inflicts on its audience. This sadism, as Gary Fisher's work introduced in chapter 3 and my discussion of *The Night Porter* in chapter 5 will also suggest, courses through varied works of art that may, if we give ourselves over to them, transform us.

Tracking how cultural objects, especially art and performance, make their imprint on us, my interest is in theorizing the mechanics of aesthetic experience. I want to probe the territory that lies beyond meaning, to offer a psychoanalytic inflection as to how theater and other forms of art develop the density of their affective contagion (Pellegrini, 2007) to produce transformative aesthetic experience. I am not reaching for hermeneutic interpretations, I am after the pulsations of experience and the mesmerizing effects we undergo in some performance. For this reason, I refuse the usual call to probe *what* is stimulated in us on the level of meaning when we are beckoned by a work of art and pay more attention to the movements magnetized in us in the encounter with an artistic event. My self-observations may, I hope, serve as a departure point for theorizing not *from* experience toward hermeneutics but *about* experience for the sake of experience alone.

In chapter 3, I discussed *Slave Play* at length and will briefly summarize it again here with a slightly different emphasis. This repetition is not only to refresh the memory of readers who have not seen the play but because, as already mentioned, repetition is both the focus *and the method* of this chapter. In other words, this repetition, much like my iterative relationship to the viewing of the play, is not just a repetition *with* a difference (Deleuze, 1968); it is a repetition *toward* a difference. I try to lay bare the mechanisms of how theater can conduct the force of "affective immersion and communal event" (Pellegrini, 2007, p. 926) and how repetition courts the reappearance of trauma by re-presenting (rather than representing) that which exists outside "lived experience" and which cannot be thought or culled into language.

Re-Presenting Slavery

All comparatively intense affective processes, including even terrifying ones, trench upon sexuality.

—Sigmund Freud, *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality*
(1905b)

On the surface, *Slave Play* appears to be concerned with the atrocious history of slavery in the antebellum South and its continued afterlife in the present. But *Slave Play* is after something quite different than inciting our horror at the institution. *Slave Play* does indeed push White audience members to discern their ongoing immersion in anti-Black racism and asks theatergoers to consider their relationship to colorism. But the edge on which *Slave Play* really vibrates is the revivification of slavery in the embodied theatrical space, bringing theatergoers into contact with how slavery's history is inscribed not only in intergenerational memory but also, and especially, in the excitable, libidinal body. *Slave Play* does not play *with* race; it demonstrates the play *of* race, “how we play race and even how race plays us” (Cruz, 2016, p. 60).

Slave Play opens with three interracial couples in a southern plantation. The White and White-passing partners subject their Black partners to different varieties of erotically tinged, racially offensive humiliations involving onstage nudity and simulated sex. These lavish, all-out assaults on dignity are rousing in the many senses of the term, an effect dexterously achieved by the playwright's capacity to harness the energy of the obscene and by his masterful use of humor, which lowers the audience's defenses. Indeed, the play is incredibly funny for those who are not too inhibited to enjoy it. These effects are further amplified by the director Robert O' Hara's calculated decision to refuse the theatergoer any reprieve from the first act's intensities by having the play run without an intermission. The first act thus operates on the psychic economy of the sexual drive: ever-intensifying excitations that escalate toward “more and more.”

In the second act, we learn that the first act's erotic debasements were staged by the Black partners, who engineered them as part of an unorthodox couples' treatment. The slave play in *Slave Play*, we thus discover, follows on the heels of a rigorous three-day prep during which

the White and White-passing partners were rigorously immersed in the materials (flashcards, vocabulary words, and movies) that they would need to enact their roles persuasively and with historical exactitude.⁴ But it is not those who were debased who most struggled: it is the White and White-passing partners who most vociferously protest. The slave play is abruptly halted by Jim, a White British man, who initially gets turned on by it but ultimately safewords, disappointing and angering his wife, who has made herself vulnerable by finally asking for what she wants.

Resolutely desexualized, the second act presents a caricatured, theory-filled exegesis that “explains” to the characters and to the audience what occurred in the preceding act. Despite its being, or perhaps because it is hyperintellectualized, this code-switching has a containing and calming effect, delivering the play’s most memorable monologues (Gary’s “I am the prize” and Kaneisha’s “You are the virus” speech). The insights are emotionally laden and difficult, but, unlike the first act, they do not leave the audience feeling disoriented or shaken up—in fact, at times, the audience applauds or otherwise expresses its approval. These lines, therefore, offer orienting moorings for understanding the first act and extend illuminating insights that theatergoers who were themselves in interracial relationships seem to have appreciated.⁵

The third act delivers a most forceful blow. Jim, who in the first act had only halfheartedly participated in the racialized sexual debasement that Kaneisha requested, belatedly gets on board. Jim now demeans Kaneisha, treating her like a slave and addressing her with racial slurs. But is his participation *real* (is he now “getting off” in racially denigrating her?), or is it *make-believe* (is he still play-acting, inflicting the racial abjection on her command)? As for Kaneisha, it is similarly unclear if she is getting what she (thought she) wanted or if she is finding herself in a hauntingly messed-up replay of her historical past (the character’s ancestors were slaves). The final scene appears to mimic a rape—and I say that it “appears to mimic a rape” because what unfolds between Kaneisha and Jim is purposefully ambiguous. On the one hand, it has many of the signifiers indexing sexual violation: there are ripped clothes, physical force, protest, resistance, anguish, and evident distress. On the other, it is portrayed in a way typical of BDSM encounters: the scene has been requested, negotiated, and orchestrated in detail. But does Kaneisha still want now what she had requested earlier?

Importantly, the rape/not-rape scene is preceded by a subtle onstage negotiation: Jim offers his whip to Kaneisha and she leans into it tentatively, biting down on it such that it becomes a gag. Later on, when Jim threatens to beat her, he strangely pauses to add, “You can nod your head” (Harris, 2018, p. 131). The stage directions for this exchange read, “Kaneisha and Jim stare at each other in a weighted silence. She slowly nods her head in the affirmative. He nods as well. She nods again” (Harris, 2018, p. 131). This nonverbal exchange may be easy to miss, but anyone acquainted with the way such communications proceed in BDSM encounters will recognize a standard method by which some tops ensure, without breaking character, that the bottom still wants what they had previously authorized. Across numerous interviews and talk-backs, Harris routinely took pains to remind the audience of this often-overlooked nuance.⁶ But if it is easy to miss, that is also because the delivery of this moment varies: even when the same actors are onstage, the nod is more or less discernible across different performances—sometimes more, sometimes less emphatic. Does this variability itself index something about the ambivalence of this interaction, as if the character, but also the actor playing Kaneisha, is herself unsure of her relationship to these repetitions? In discussing this, Antoinette Crowe-Legacy, one of the actresses who have played Kaneisha, notes that the nod is as if Kaneisha were saying, “I am not completely sure, but I think I have to do this, I need this. And I think,” Crowe-Legacy continues, “that living in that place is hard. It’s hard to live in an ‘I don’t know’. . . It’s hard to press forward when you feel that there is possibly something that could go very right or very wrong” (Sunday discussions, January 23, 2022).

This nonverbal aspect of her exchange with Jim (the nod, the biting of the whip) is where we see the bending of Kaneisha’s will. What Kaneisha takes a chance on, the kind of erotic experience and interpersonal engagement she is risking escapes affirmative consent, even as it shares its signifiers. What we see unfold on the stage is not a nonverbally expressed “yes” but a movement inside the self not based on reason but animated by the drive (limit consent)—what Crowe-Legacy describes as Kaneisha having to do this, needing this. (Here let us also remember Carmen, from the introduction, for whom consent was an interior affair.) Limit consent, we see in Kaneisha, proliferates in the body, which affirmative consent sees only as unreliable or dangerous. Kaneisha’s nonverbal vocab-

ulary of actions (the nodding of the head, the biting of the whip) index what cannot be spoken, what cannot make it into words, and it is here, to return to Moten, that we may listen for something that is not there and yet could be made audible. Some audiences interpreted the last act as a rape, but saying with certainty that Kaneisha was raped may be the audience's own attempt to bind and thus to master the undecidability of the closing scene, which confronts us with something at the limits of what we can grasp. To assume the kind of risk Kaneisha takes requires a sense of self-sovereignty: one has to have a will before one can bend it. Her form of eroticism allows her to engage with something that may produce overwhelm, not only violation; and in that sense, self-destructiveness at such moments does not reside in taking a risk *but in failing to take it*.

Before long, however, the scene becomes too tangled even for those who are familiar with BDSM signifiers and the nuances of consent. Jim forcefully pins Kaneisha down, entering her violently. She mildly fights back. He keeps going. She pushes Jim, and when he still keeps going, she scratches him.⁷ Finally scrambling out from underneath him, she pierces the audience's stunned silence with a harrowing wail. She begins to sob. What is unfolding is tipping into the abyss. Are we watching Jim rape his wife, or is he taking her against her protests as per the scripted sexual play? The indeterminacy of this scene becomes a particle accelerator, sending questions about consent into a tailspin. Even as Kaneisha had nodded her head, she no longer wants this—though we cannot know if it is because it comes too late, or because she did not quite realize what she was opening herself to, or something else entirely. “The risk of emotional damage can be great,” warns Mollena Williams (2010, p. 56), to whom we will loop back later in this chapter.

What does it mean for a Black woman to ask to be play-raped by her White husband against an ancestral background in which female slaves were stripped of the right to withhold their consent (Hartman, 1997; Musser, 2016, 2018; Spillers, 1987)? What to make of the play's ending, where Kaneisha thanks Jim for listening, is the subject of much postplay conjecture. The play ends with the force of shock and at the site of rekindled enigma, refusing to tell us what we are to make of this jolting mess. The playwright has us leave the theater rattled and without consolation, disturbed about what we have just watched and confused about what he and the play itself want from us.

Harris's refusal to tell the viewer what to do with or about the blazing intensities of the third act is its own enigmatic surplus. In interviews and talk-backs, he routinely declines to comment on what the takeaway is supposed to be. For Antoinette Crowe-Legacy, "there is debate inside of myself about how much [Kaneisha] is hurt by the end of the play and by what specifically, as she gets closer to what she asks for" (Sunday discussions, December 19, 2021). The play's argument, if one can be attributed to it, is that the history of slavery remains nested in the bodies of both White and Black subjects, in a state that Scarfone has called the "unpast" (2015b). It is unpast because the past is not yet past but, instead, resurfaces and reappears in the present where it agitates us through the libidinal body. In *Slave Play*, this reappearance materializes at the margin of our (the audience's) consent. Harris re-presents this unpast, not in the sense of representing it but in the sense of presenting it again (Scarfone, 2015b), calling it forth in the theatrical space by means of its outlandish erotic charge (Holland, 2012).⁸ This re-presentation of White America's foundational crime is, to borrow Schneider's expression, a masterful slashing of the imaginary membrane that separates the past from the present (2011). "The time of slavery persists," writes Hartman, in the interminable "longing for a way of undoing the past" (1997, p. 6)—but in *Slave Play*, the longings are infinitely more grotesque, hoping not to undo the past but to dramatize it in real time.

These dramatizations do not seem to me to be rote repetitions but inciting traumatizations. Midway through the third act, Kaneisha explains that her enslaved elders have been watching her and Jim: "[They have been] watching me lay in bed every night with a demon who thinks he is a saint. And the elders don't care that you are a demon, they lay with them too. . . . They just want you to know it. And me to know it. So I can lie with grace. So I can lie with their blessing" (Harris, 2018, p. 129).⁹ Rihanna's "Work" plays in the background—"I mean who am I to hold your past against you? I just hope that it gets to you. I hope that you see this through. I hope that you see this true"—which helps frame Kaneisha's ask: this is not just her history, it is Jim's too.

In a classic essay on the historical palimpsest of Black female sexual exploitation that moves from slavery to the present, Hortense Spillers writes, "Whether or not the captive female and/or her sexual oppressor derived 'pleasure' from their seductions and couplings is not a question

we can politely ask. Whether or not ‘pleasure’ is possible at all under conditions that I would aver as non-freedom . . . has not been settled” (1987, p. 76). For Musser, settling this question is a sheer impossibility “because our understandings of pleasure rely on contemporary notions of individuality and personhood, which cannot be grafted onto the historical reality of slavery” (2014, p. 165).¹⁰ What can we do with questions that are impolite, questions that cannot be settled because the terms that organize them are historically inapposite to the time of our query? We can, I propose, give ourselves over to the force of their action on us. To explain what I mean by that, let us turn to the use of humor in the play, which gives Harris a way to tackle the questions that Spillers frames as impolite without addressing them head-on, which would be nothing less than inflammatory. To take them on directly, Harris elaborates, would be “almost like punching you in the face. But if you laugh. . . all of a sudden you’ve opened yourself up and are consenting to, like, more. . . You want more of that, because it’s so funny. . . Your mouth gets wider and wider and wider, and then I just throw ideas down it” (Smith, 2019). *Slave Play*’s jokes do not secure the audience’s informed consent; they act, rather, as (Laplanchean) seductions, thereby implicating limit consent in the lowering of our defenses, which means that the jokes strewn through the play exact a strange form of participation from the audience, working on us at the limits of our assent, pressing us into discomfort while also transfixing us through their aggression, an aggression that is also, specifically, sexual.

The laughter the play coaxes is thus part of its strategic approach, a way for Harris to engage the questions Spillers describes as impolite.¹¹ Seduction, as we have seen, happens not with or against our consent but at its limit—and we may remember here how Mia felt seduced and, thus, “screwed” by me after I told her my fee. Many theatergoers attend a play expecting something to unfold onstage, not expecting something bewildering and strange to unfold in themselves. There are expectations as to what we think we are agreeing to when we enter the theatrical space, what we believe we are stepping into and are prepared for, and we may not even know we have such expectations. It is only in retrospect, when these expectations are broken or dashed, as was the case with some *Slave Play* audiences, that we become aware of them. But this is also precisely what makes some performances so potent: what is stirred up cannot pos-

sibly be negotiated through any kind of ordinary or affirmative consent. These kind of aesthetic experiences are in the province of limit consent; they do not give us closure but reveal the teeming of contradiction. By lifting established meanings from their everyday coercions, such aesthetic experiences stand to rattle the ego. Such rattling takes something familiar and puts it into a foreign context so that we can be slowed down, wrested away from our habituated thinking (Adorno, 1970).

The question of whether one can consent to being rattled is, in many ways, one of the themes that is threaded throughout this volume. Many theatergoers ruminate on the third act in the hope of some clarification, to get a better grasp of whether Jim genuinely listened to Kaneisha. What this may miss is that the closing act is not conjugated according to our usual ways of assessing whether someone was “heard” but breaks down, instead, the very terms by which we measure whether “listening” has happened. What all subjects need, and what Black subjects in general and Black women in particular are often denied, is listening for “interiority, difference, and relational standing” (Chambers-Letson, 2020, p. 279). Many theatergoers understood *Slave Play* as giving White audiences a way to reckon with how their own racialization materializes in the flickering shadow of histories of domination.¹² To me, what the closing act more radically offers is not racial education but a reordering of the terms by which we are accustomed to thinking about sexuality, racial difference, intimacy, and agency. This is not a reordering that happens through instruction, and it has no determinate end; it has to be risked by the audience’s willingness to undergo aesthetic experience. My guess is that some “repeaters,” those theatergoers who went back time and again to see *Slave Play*, may have also returned to experience something summoned in themselves. That certainly was the case for me.

The Driving Force of Repetition

In psychoanalysis, repetition has a bad reputation because it is mostly regarded as a degraded form of remembering. Necessitated by the absence of other, higher-quality mnemonic inscription, repetition is considered problematic in that it requires the action of, rather than the symbolization of, what is repressed. A truncated overview of these ideas follows to help contextualize my intervention.

In 1914, Freud posited repetition compulsion as a form of remembering through action. Repetition is how the repressed returns: the patient repeats “without . . . knowing that he is repeating” (1914b, p. 150). Repetition was thus “a present-day force” (1914b, p. 151) that encysted mnemonic traces. This encystment permitted them to be conducted into the present, but it also muted them, making repetition an obstacle to recollection. Freud’s advice to analysts about this problem was to give repetition unencumbered latitude in the circumscribed space of the transference, so that the patient’s relationship with the analyst would become a playground “in which [repetition] is allowed to expand in almost complete freedom” (1914b, p. 154). This opened a path for the unremembered events of the past to come alive, to be dramatized in the transference space. Analysis of these repetitions would then help the patient remember and narratively symbolize the past, effectively rehousing anamnesis from the domain of action to the psychic sphere. Freud later formulated repetition compulsion as a relentless, unstoppable return to the site of trauma that is driven, as mentioned in earlier chapters, by a demonic force (1920). From this angle, repetition compulsion’s hope is to master trauma, and it is always doomed to fail. Repetition, that is, botches the project it sets out to accomplish—to master the traumatic past. Between that and repetition’s reliance on the re-presentation and the restaging of trauma rather than the higher-grade, symbolic form of remembering, psychoanalysis has thus regarded repetition as a necessary evil.

Psychoanalytic theorizing has since covered much ground regarding repetition. Epigrammatically here, the psychoanalyst Bruce Reis has described *creative* repetitions that do not repeat as fixation but that instead carry “a yield of pleasure” (2020, p. 104). By inviting pleasure rather than iterative suffering, creative repetitions open up paths to the possibilities of new experience. Other theorists are also nuancing our understanding of repetition, providing well-theorized and sensitively handled clinical material in which pleasure, the patient’s and the analyst’s, becomes critical to the patient’s repetition being churned toward creative outcomes (Schwartz-Cooney, 2018; L. Levine, 2016).

I find this theorizing expansive and helpful in that it has lifted repetition out of its entrenched, previously devalued position. But, at the same time, this foregrounding of pleasure strips repetition of its more destabilizing dimensions, which means that a repetition that is rehabilitated

through pleasure loses its footing in the demonic. This move relocates the problem of repetition to a taxonomical divide between pleasurable and, therefore, creative repetitions and those that are more demonic and, therefore, destructive. What about repetitions, however, like my own with *Slave Play*, which embroil pleasure with vertiginous difficulty? Engaging in them involves a bending of the will, a countering of the ego's tendency to repeat mechanically, and a resistance to being pulled into our customary understandings/translations. Chance also plays a role as to how such repetitions will proceed and whether they will come to constitute traumatizations, and this chance factor is also why this form of experience cannot be preplanned. Further, we oftentimes rely on the *effects* of repetition to adjudicate whether they are creative or destructive. The outcome of repetition, however, relies on many factors, including factors outside repetition itself.

If a clear distinction between creative and destructive repetitions can only be claimed retroactively, we may have to concede that the force of repetition may be agnostic, that it can go either way depending, each time, on the interplay of binding and unbinding. For example, I very much enjoyed *Slave Play*, and it, no doubt, spurred a creative process in me. But to say only that something generative came out of my enjoyment of a play that so graphically re-presents the sexual atrocities of slavery and that stirs the audience with intemperate displays of erotic abjection would be to leave out the baser and rawer elements that drew me, and so many others, to it. It is, in fact, this very perturbing enjoyment that this play in particular and difficult performance overall artfully stimulates in theatergoers. And here is the rub: since the sexual is agnostic as to ethics, that is, since it is not subordinated to moral reasoning, its evocation opens up to a range of possibilities—not just pleasure but also cruelty, not just creative potential but also barbarism. It is only in the *après-coup*, then, that we will be able to know what came of these forces and to what effects they were used, which is another way of saying that repetition is not a project with a determinate end. It is us, speaking always in its aftermath after knowing what repetition came to, who confound repetition's effects with its causes.

As for my own repetitive relationship to *Slave Play*, the aesthetic experience I had caused something in me to shift: at the moment, I could not capture in words what I was experiencing. I only knew that it was

drawing me closer to my being, to something enigmatic and opaque that I still cannot put into words. To do so would be to defile the experience I had. In the proceeding months, as I continued to attend performances, the play was gradually transformed into an object of contemplation that made me think of consent and sadism in new ways. But that is only what happened *after* the experience: it is the set of translations that I forged in order to cope with the strain the play produced in me. In that sense, while I can tell you *what* I have done conceptually with this play (and the ideas in this book are partly derived from that process), I do not have access, nor can you, to the more enigmatic, opaque elements that drew me to it so feverishly.

What I do know is that in its aftermath, I was singularly changed: I came to this country as an immigrant from two home countries in my twenties, one with virtually no racial diversity or conversations about race (Greece) and the other (Cyprus) released only in the mid-twentieth century from the tight grip of British rule, with virtually no appreciation of its postcoloniality. Upon coming to the States, I worked hard to develop an understanding of my racialization and to appreciate the workings of racial dynamics in the United States. So nuanced thinking about race was not new to me when I came to *Slave Play*; I had done serious and dedicated intellectual work, and my social and personal life had been far from monochromatic. Still, *Slave Play* gave me an experience of overwhelm that tore up my ego, and in that opening, something new was forged. No matter how much time I had previously spent thinking about race, the experience of *Slave Play* did something that could not have happened otherwise. But, for the purposes of this book, *how* the play acted on me is less important than *that* it did—though, again, it is impossible to talk about the latter without mentioning the former. What matters, in other words, is not my personal transformation per se: the fact that this transformation happened speaks to *how* some theater and performance exercise a force on us that can shatter and transform us.

What mattered most to me during the period of my iterative infatuation was not what I learned from *Slave Play* or how I was changed by it; these coagulated later, after the play had taken residence in me, and are merely its outward manifestations. What mattered most was the *aesthetic experience itself*, not what it touched in me or what it meant to me but the contact with something alien and foreign to me. Even as I was

unable to articulate it to myself at the time, and even as I still stumble for words to recount it today, having that experience again and again is something that I valued and that I fiercely, despite some cost to myself, protected. Repetition of the kind I experienced with *Slave Play*, in other words, is about something much more sacred than even creativity: it can usher us into experiences that vibrate at the highest intensity of being.

Sovereign Experience

And sometimes working within me you open for me a door into a state of feeling which is quite unlike anything to which I am accustomed—a kind of sweet delight which, if I could only remain permanently in that state, would be something not of this world, not of this life.

—Augustine, *Confessions* 10.40 (qtd. in Miles, 2021, p. 3)

In chapters 2 and 3, we explored how repetition works to progressively wear down the binding of psychic energy, energetically overwhelming the ego's bindings, causing its shattering. Repetition escalates toward overwhelm by delivering traumatizations (not trauma but psychic and/or physical pain) that work at the limit of our consent. For example, I gave myself over to the play, thus permitting it to “work on” me: it “worked on” me by rousing certain forces and appetites that I came into contact with obliquely through attending the play and at the Sunday discussions that, as I mentioned, I also felt unable to resist. Repeating traumatizations operate like a persistent microdosing of pain. With enough buildup, this microdosing can bring about a state of overwhelm, inciting a crisis in the organized ego, dissipating its boundaries.¹³ Overwhelm unravels the connective tissue between translations and enigma/the sexual unconscious, which is another way of saying that existing translations become unbound. Unbinding releases psychic energy that is too much for the psyche to bear. The ego will, therefore, quickly go into overdrive to suture up the open wound; as it assembles anew, new selves become possible.

Indeed, let us now examine at a higher resolution what happens *within* the domain of overwhelm, in the interstitial space after the ego has come into contact with the drive but before it repairs itself by cre-

ating a new structure.¹⁴ The space between de-subjectivation and re-subjectivation opens up a contact zone with the drive and is the domain of pure experience—as opposed to an experience *of* something. In this interstitial space, one may undergo a very fleeting divestment from the burdens of subjectivity (the unbinding of the ego), to luxuriate in what Bataille called “sovereign experience” (1954, p. 113)—a transitory burst of intense liveliness during which “attention passes from ‘projects,’” that is, teleologically oriented actions, to deliver a “startled jump of our entire being” (1954, p. 113).

To prevent any misunderstandings of the loaded term “sovereignty,” I want to clarify that I am not referring to a process by which one attains a durable sense of self-possession that is vacated of personal history, historical events, or social forces. Nor am I unaware of the complex political lineages around indigeneity, tribal land claims, and anticolonial movements that trail the term “sovereignty.” Sovereign experience is also not meant to codify an autonomous self as fantasized, promised, and sold to us by neoliberalism, a self, that is, that wills choices and selects experience as if from a smorgasbord of consumerist options. Sovereign experience, in the sense I am discussing it, is also not about the acquisition and consolidation of institutional power as when used in political theory (i.e., in the sense of political sovereignty). Sovereign experience, as I use the term, is a burst of self-divestment that arises in the confrontation of being with nonbeing, when everything is put on the line (Blanchot, 1969). Bataille’s “idiosyncratic concept” of sovereignty, Martin Jay writes, “meant the loss of willed control by a homogeneous agent [aka the subject] and submission to the heterogeneous forces that exploded its integrity” (1993, p. 67). Therein, an immeasurably brief escape from the pummeling effects of political projects, discourse, and organized meanings becomes possible (Bataille, 1957).

This very fleeting separation from identitarian projects and from the demands of the political realm can make sovereign experience feel immensely freeing. Because it offers a (short-lived) span outside subjectivity, it makes a powerful claim on the present, an ephemeral psychic space where—contra Hegel—we do not rely on the other to recognize our existence or to affirm our self-consciousness but we can luxuriate, instead, in the formlessness of being. This is as intimate an experience as one can undergo *with oneself*. We may think of it as an encounter with

our opacity, a meaningful encounter with the limit of what we can know or access about ourselves.

Sovereign experience is a most private and personal space, although here words fail me. When I say “personal,” I do not mean it from the perspective of the ego or from an “I” that speaks for itself or from the standpoint of an organized self. The experiential domain I am describing is the opposite of notions of “lived experience” in the sense of first-hand accounts or in the way the term “experience” is used nowadays to describe the conscious reporting of living as a member of a particular group. None of this relieves us from the ways in which we are dependent on one another or ethically responsible for the other, but it does offer a furtive relief from the lacerating demands of relationality. Transiently stripped from the workings of power, discourse, and self-narrativization, sovereign experience can feel like a boundless sense of freedom—though I want to stress that by “freedom,” I am not referring to an emancipation from persons or structures. What we are momentarily freed from is the burden of identity-driven and/or hermeneutic understandings of the self. We are not liberated, that is, from anything other than our own selves, momentarily startled by the arbitrariness of our own translations—though even that is only immeasurably brief. Still, when it happens, we are momentarily exposed to the raw nerve of being.

What does it mean, though, for experience to “flash” before us? I do not mean that something previously bewildering becomes illuminated or comes into crisper focus. In sovereign experience, time comes to a heightened standstill, interrupting the flow of chronological time. A jolting reorientation to the present, it refuses the ability of future time to hold sway over us. Sovereign time is thus not a progressive onward march but an intensified “now,” a hyperpixilated present in which time does not pass. The temporality of sovereign experience is akin to Scarfone’s notion of “actual time,” “a very specific kind of present, not [an] eternal but [an] atemporal [one]” (2015b, p. 77)—“atemporal” being the word by which Freud described the time of the unconscious (1915c). Scarfone distinguishes between time that is eternal, where one may be caught in an inescapable, ongoing loop, and time that is atemporal, time that vibrates with the intensity of *now*. This implies a vital difference between stalled time and still time, that is, between time that is “stuck” in the unpast and time that, in its stillness, may become coextensive with

experience. In stilled time, we find ourselves in a pronounced now with no temporal unfolding, where we may be fully claimed by the present. Arising in the crevasses of the ego's dissolution, where our very being is at stake, sovereign experience stands to bring us into contact with the extravagance of life.

The high-energy psychic states arising during overwhelm are quickly transduced to new translations that, one hopes, will work better than the ones that have been broken down by the force of repetition. Whatever feels new, creative, or even clarifying issues from what the ego crafts *after the fact, as a way of patching up the hole opened up by overwhelm*. Creativity, if it occurs, is not about the opening up of the ego but what is left behind when it gets stitched together anew. Any amelioration, however, that arises through this process is by no means guaranteed—*nor is it the goal of repetition*. A “better translation” (e.g., my new relationship to my racialization) is not the telos but merely an epiphenomenon, a side effect, if you will, of the ego's expeditious work, which is to promptly restore itself to a more intact, enclosed state. Translations crafted in the wake of sovereign experience arise through the anguish and the toil of overwhelm and are hard-earned. Crucially, because they carry inside them a rudimentary trace that an experience of sovereignty was endured, they may feel especially valuable and, in some ways, more “ours.”

The “It” That Repeats Has to Appear: The Actual and the Enigmatic

The intense clarity of the image failed to satisfy us, for it seemed to hide as much as it revealed; and while it seemed to invite us to pierce the veil and examine the mystery behind it, its luminous concreteness nevertheless held the eye entranced and kept it from probing deeper.

—Nietzsche, *Birth of Tragedy*

In Freudian repetition compulsion, as we saw, the subject repeats (rather than remembers) something “forgotten” or something that, being unacceptable to the self, was repressed, that is, relocated to the unconscious. But Laplanche does not subscribe to Freud's “jigsaw puzzle model” (2006a, p. 127) of memory. Whereas for Freud repression marks

something that has gone missing, for Laplanche, it is the inescapable fate of the enigmatic surfeit. So if, for Freud, repetition is the return of the repressed, in Laplanchean thought repetition would have to mean something different than the reappearance of a painful or unacceptable inscription. The “it” that galvanizes repetition, that is, would not be an obscured memory but would relate to what is at the origin of primal repression: the ontological trauma of enigma itself. But how, we would be justified to ask, can that trauma repeat when enigma is itself a hollow, devoid of content? It repeats, I would say, as experience, or, to be (slightly) more precise, as a contentless experience that puts us *in the presence* of the unknown. Repetition in this sense does not represent some thing: it re-presents, in the sense of presenting again *an originary experience*. How would we sense its recurrence? We sense it, Scarfone notes, by its propulsive force, where it has “the effect of presence,” “convey[ing] something more and something other than the semantic order” (2015b, pp. 117–118).

To make this a bit less abstract, let us consider Scarfone’s description of the fresco of the Annunciation in the Oratory of San Giorgio in Padua. “Lodged in the very middle of the classic scene,” he writes, “between the annunciating angel and the Virgin. . . is an oculus, a sort of rose window through which, in the daytime, a blinding light usually shines” (2015b, p. 71). To enjoy the visual experience, visitors “must give time for their eyes to adjust to this luminous irruption” (2015b, p. 71). What first appears as an interference to being able to look at the fresco “turns out to be an extraordinary deepening of the aesthetic,” as this particular placement is exploited by the artist not just to represent the scene of the Annunciation but to perform the action of “*annunciat[ing]*, *summoning* the spectator who soon feels seized by this light, without which nothing can be seen, but under whose spell one is but half-blinded” (2015b, p. 72; emphasis in original).

For Scarfone, the draw one feels to the oculus is akin to being exposed to a mysterious presence that is felt to almost personally address the visitor. By incorporating this oculus into the fresco, the artist has been able to conduct the sun’s luminosity, which gives the artwork an intensity that draws one in but from which one also has to turn away. Together, the two give the visit its experiential depth, as this unmediated stream of light is responsible for the scene having become much more gripping than any Annunciation scene, however beautifully executed, ever could.

The oculus thus becomes a source of “a profundity going far beyond what is represented, endowing [the fresco] with a presence, granting it the status of a *presentation*” (Scarfone, 2015b, p. 73). This presentation is potent, but its potency does not inhere in its offering understanding (e.g., of the mystery of the Annunciation); it derives from the fact that “it marks the limits of representation, signal[ing] the existence of something beyond the representable, the intelligible, something beyond meaning, an ungraspable core, an opaque or empty nucleus dwelling at the heart of any representation” (2015b, p. 73). Scarfone relates the experience of the oculus to what lies at the core of our being, to the “foundational and insurmountable fact” of the opaque nucleus implanted by enigma. This nucleus, akin to the enigmatic core, obtains from the infant’s failed efforts to translate the adult’s sexual unconscious. Borrowing Freud’s term “actual,” Scarfone refers to it as the internal alienness that always remains inside us in unelaborated form, resistant to any and all of our efforts to understand or symbolize it. On the one hand, the actuality at the core of our being poses an obstacle to understanding; on the other, this enigmatic depth preserves inside us something mysterious that cannot be appropriated by discourse, that cannot be exhaustively understood through language, and that resists being organized in the sphere of identity.

The ego cannot eliminate the actual or fully “know” it; it can only shroud it in something else in an effort to dissipate its strangeness, into something more hermeneutically familiar. This does not obliterate its enigmatic power, but it does succeed in making it seem more graspable, which is another way of saying that it offers the actual a way of hiding in plain sight. Like the purloined letter, the actual is obvious yet also obstructed by the obviousness in which it is coated. Importantly, a goodness of fit has to exist between the actual and its coating. This “fit” is neither a complete correspondence nor a total strangeness but a matter of an energetic match (I am obviously referring here to psychic energy). Trauma, especially in its imbrication with the excitable body, is an opportune coating for this function, because it definitionally involves inassimilable psychic energy. Thus, events of our past that have wounded us, be they personal, generational, or cultural, are especially likely to draw us closer to experience, offering shroudings that may be “stickier” (Ahmed, 2004), more readily linking up with the excitation of enigma.

Slave Play, as we have come to see, is a double entendre: on the surface, it announces itself as being a play “about” slavery. But it is not—at least not exactly. The play is about how slavery’s history pulsates through the present, but it is not about slavery per se (not in the way that, say, *Amistad* or *12 Years a Slave* is). Slavery, we might say, as a documented and known historical event, becomes the shrouding, the known element that the ego uses to scotomize the strangeness of a raw, racialized, sadomasochistic sexuality. One might justifiably ask: how can something as horrific as slavery be seen as a shrouding? It is worth remembering here that the shrouding is not slavery itself but the discourse around it. Trauma discourse, to say it differently, centers rather than decenters the ego; it organizes the way we see the world and offers translational tools with which to master the disquiet of enigma. It is the second meaning of “slave play” that the upper case of the title shrouds, and as such, the title *Slave Play* simultaneously points to and away from race play, to a raw, racialized, traumatophilic sexuality. Race play does, of course, draw on the sexual crimes of slavery, but it also enrolls the complex erotic syntax of the sexual drive’s infantile sexuality: sadism, masochism, voyeurism, nongenital pleasures, part-object functioning, and degenitalized excitements, excitements that are distributed across “the entire cutaneous surface” (Freud, 1905b, p. 201).

If you are doubtful that something as horrific as slavery can become a coating, consider how even with the words “Slave Play” on the marquee, some theatergoers still felt tricked by the playwright, asserting that they did not know what they were walking into—and thereby implicitly invoking the metric of affirmative consent. They seemed to be saying, “We should have been told what we were getting into,” a demand that overlaps with contemporary conversations and battles over trigger warnings. Introducing trigger warnings into a play imports into it the neoliberal demand that we be offered a detailed inventory of what emotional experiences are on offer before we decide if we will want to consume them. Let us leave aside, however, the sheer impossibility of such a “warning”—because who would be able to anticipate, and on what basis, how exactly a work of art will “hit” any one of us? Let us wonder instead why the title of the play was not seen (by those who protested) as having issued a warning that difficult materials would be addressed? Is the issue that the play does not tell us what it is “about,” or is the problem

that the “impolite” questions (Spillers) raised by the play (about the slave play in *Slave Play*) cannot be asked directly or seen head-on? What kind of warning could possibly prepare anyone for the feelings that this play might evoke, even if the artist were prepared to issue it? Much like the oculus, which cannot be looked at directly but which, nevertheless is responsible for the deepened experience, this topic is just too incandescent and the affective charge around it too intense to be bearable, sending the ego into overdrive in order to shroud it into something more familiar and respectable.¹⁵

It might seem odd for me to be suggesting that slavery is the respectable and less difficult shrouding. In so doing, I do not intend to minimize its horrors but to underscore that even known, hellish nightmares are preferable to the ego than to risk its own undoing. Affirmative consent here proves itself, once again, to be more allied with the conservative work of the ego (that is, the ego’s work to conserve itself) rather than with the new self- and world-making possibilities of limit consent and the exigent sadism enabled by limit consent, to which we will turn shortly.

The Artist and the Pervert

In February 2016, the *New York Times* published a piece titled “A Composer and His Wife: Creativity through Kink” (Woolfe, 2016). The article focused on Mollena Williams-Haas, whom we encountered earlier in this chapter, and her husband, Georg Friedrich Haas, one of the world’s leading microtonal composers. The couple live in a 24/7 kinky relationship. The article’s author, Zachary Woolfe, refrains from stating explicitly that their particular type of dominant/submissive arrangement is organized around their racial difference. For example, it does not mention that Williams-Haas’s life is dedicated to serving Haas, who, prior to meeting her, had considerable trouble accepting his desires as a sadistic sexual dominant, but it only hints at their kink’s racialized character. For example, there is mention of Williams-Haas keeping a blog called *The Perverted Negress* but not of her advocacy around race play; it references her nicknaming Haas “Herr Meister” as if it is done in jest, when she regularly addresses him as “Master” and “Sir”; and the photo accompanying the article shows her wearing a collar around her neck but leaves out that it signifies his “ownership” of her (Woolfe, 2016).

Drawing our attention to while also prying it away from “the erotic life of racism” (Holland, 2012), the piece grinds up against the couple’s perversity. Ultimately, however, it recoils, staying within the more dignified confines of their successful heterosexual marriage, which—and this is much emphasized—boosts the husband’s productivity, something underlined in the article’s title.¹⁶ The article, we might say, masks what it also puts on display: by highlighting Haas’s coming-out narrative as a sexual dominant, it evades the difficulties of sadomasochistic interracial desire that, sex positivity aside, syncs up all too well with the history of slavery—and Williams-Haas’s ancestors, it should be noted, were slaves. While the article boasts that Haas’s creative output has “roughly doubled,” we are not told what this has to do with Williams-Haas having become what he calls his “muse.”

I do not minimize that coming out can feel freeing, and I am in support of people having sex in whichever way and with whatever body parts or objects they desire. Nor do I dismiss the impact that this relationship has had on Haas’s work. Rather, I am moving in a rather different direction, to explore what links perversity may have with trauma and inspiration.

I am not convinced that Haas’s transformed relationship to his art straightforwardly proceeded from the affirmation of his identity as a sexual dominant alone. The idea that the affirmation of his identity is key is in itself part of the mythosymbolic realm (that discovering our true sexual desires will be liberating) and may well be Haas’s own translation. In fact, I would insist that what deserves our attention in Haas’s work is not his increased productivity per se—which reduces his art to the vulgarity of the assembly line—but the transformation of his aesthetic relationship to it. “When I’m writing [music now],” he explains, “I feel more concentrated, at ease, lighter than I used to. I no longer need composition as a form of psychotherapy. Instead, it’s become a spiritual act; in exploring the world of sound, I venture into places . . . other people look for that feeling in religion” (Brown, 2016). Such remarkable transformations may not inhere in the reassurances of our being “seen” by the other (those reassurances do psychic work, too, though of a different kind) but may have more to do with the rousing of inspiration, the kindling, that is, of psychic energy—a process that falls under the aegis of primal seduction and that differs from sublimation, which

consists of a utile, socially acceptable channeling of the drive. I draw out these arguments through materials around Williams-Haas and Haas's relationship—interviews, writings, and the documentary of their relationship, *The Artist and the Pervert*—using them as springboards for my thinking about traumatophilia. To be clear, these are not attempts to psychoanalyze them as individuals but, rather, to draw on them to further fine-tune the conceptual apparatus I am proposing.

As an experienced race-play activist and also as a Black submissive woman, Williams-Haas says in the documentary that she has often had to explain, if not defend, her sexuality against charges of false consciousness, or of dissociated collusions with Whiteness. In the documentary and elsewhere (Williams, 2009a, 2009b, 2009c, 2009d), Williams-Haas responds to the critique that her sexuality undermines gains made by feminist activism by arguing that what makes her submission agentic is the fact that she is willing the conditions of her domination. As to the charge that her racial submission disrespects the legacy of slavery, offering problematic representations of Black sexuality, she refuses to be interpellated into representing her entire race. Categorically rejecting the notion that her sexuality needs to be respectable *because* she is Black, she writes irreverently, “my vagina isn’t really interested in uplifting the race” (Williams, 2009a). “To say I can’t play my personal psychodrama out just because I’m black, *that’s* racist” (Woolfe, 2016).

To think alongside Williams-Haas and Haas's relationship, let us turn to some further conceptual clarifications.

Implantation, Intromission, and the Touching of Wounds

We have already seen how the trauma of implantation involves the incursion of the adult's sexual otherness into the infant. The adult's psychic trespass into us never gets fully processed in the sense of being “resolved” or completely symbolized. Instead, as we have seen, it becomes partly appropriated into the ego, becoming shrouded in secondary meanings through the ego's fantasizing function (translation). But a remainder lingers, always present as an internal foreign body that eventually constitutes our sexual unconscious, sometimes agitating and at others traumatizing us from within when that wound is touched. Next, I want to explore the draw to touch—and our resistances to

touching—these unfathomable implantative wounds, wounds to which we are inexplicably drawn by what Laplanche described as the sexual drive’s “exigency.” Exigency, he writes, “is the object that keeps knocking at the door, this intruder, this other within us which we still refer to . . . as the Unconscious” (Laplanche, 2006a, p. 278). The exigency of our alterity, of our own strangeness to ourselves, fascinates and compels us.

Implantation, I remind you, is a normatively traumatic process, as opposed to intromission, which is contingently traumatic in the sense that it may or not occur. Intromission *foists* meaning on the infant, it comes with an interdiction against the infant’s independent fantasizing activity around a traumatic event. Consider, for instance, a little girl who goes to her mother to say that her uncle touched her “down there” and who is told, “You must be confused,” or that “nothing happened” and that she should stop making trouble. This girl is now dealing not only with the impact of the sexual abuse itself but also with the mother’s forbidding her to think about what happened and to make meaning of it. The mother’s communication, “You must be confused” does not just inflict the harm of neglect and disbelief: it is also a demand that the girl *be and remain* confused. That demand is jammed into the child’s mind to short-circuit the girl’s autonomous meaning-making process. Or consider a Black family that petitions the state for justice following the death of a family member killed by a police officer, only to be told, in the form of a not-guilty verdict, that “nothing worthy of attention happened here.” This prohibition against one’s own separate meaning-making may be resisted (after all, Black communities know very well *what* happened), but that does not make it any less soul-killing or crazy-making.

For Laplanche and for Laplanchean scholars (Fletcher, 2007; House, 2017; Tessier, 2020), the distinction between implantation and intromission is critical. Implantation is normatively traumatic and thus developmentally inevitable, whereas intromission exceptionalizes trauma as something contingent and avoidable. Under intromission, one’s translations are forced by external diktats, forced into translating this way or another. We may, thus, think of intromission as the trauma of a mind-fuck—a word I use intentionally to mark how the interdiction to translate freely is disrupted by the other’s sexual unconscious.

I am not persuaded, however, that the distinction between the trauma of intromission and the trauma of implantation is as conceptually wa-

tertight as Laplanche has intimated. I would actually suggest that the opposite is true and that implantations are by far more difficult. This is because in intromission there is at least a possibility, even if in the *après-coup*, to identify what was done to us, to name, that is, the injury, to pinpoint its origin, or to mark its precise interpersonal location. This is not so with implantation, however, where the other's sexual unconscious pierces us enigmatically and without our distinct awareness from the get-go, leaving behind a deposit that sets in motion the process of our becoming. Further, intromission is also a message: the interdiction to translate freely is, actually, a message (of prohibition). As any other message, therefore, intromissions also carry an enigmatic charge. Intromission, in other words, always has an implantative dimension. The mother who tells her daughter, "Your uncle didn't mean it that way," or a court that avers that the killing of a Black teenager was "self-defense" are not merely conveying "messages" (e.g., about which lives matter); they also introduce something inscrutably perplexing (e.g., Why do Black lives not matter and White lives do?).

The fact that intromissions are always laced with implantations is not a problem. In fact, it should give us hope because what that means is that all trauma, even the most heinous, has an enigmatic surcharge that can be retranslated. To say this differently, all trauma leaves behind a snag. This snag is akin to a loose thread in a sweater that, if pulled repeatedly and without interruption, can unweave the sweater (in this case, the narrative) completely. To flesh out the metaphor, traumatophilic revisitations of the implantative dimension of full-fledged trauma are equivalent to the action of pulling on the thread of the ego. What stands to come undone is nothing less than the subject's translations (not the fact of the traumatic event but how it's been narrativized). What this undoes is not trauma itself but the ego's relation to it. Because the implantative dimension is closely tied to the enigmatic and the infantile sexual, traumatophilic repetitions give us a way to understand what Freud means when he says that trauma makes sexuality active again (Laplanche, 1994/2014). Even the most explicitly horrifying and heinous crimes, or perhaps especially those, generate a remainder that can never be fully assimilated: these may be questions like, "What did that smug look on Derek Chauvin's face mean?" We can hypothesize, but the point is that even when the facts are incontestable—depicted on lynching postcards, recorded on body cams,

caught on a passerby's cell phone—an enigmatic overflow endures. This traumatophilic pulling of the thread is easier said than done: as we have seen, the ego will mightily resist any contestation of its structural integrity, which is why repetition's demonic force is critical to traumatisms building the momentum to overcome the ego's defenses and overwhelm it.

Because traumatophilic repetitions lean on the sexual drive, they can look—and often are—perplexingly superfluous, even extravagant. What gives traumatophilia its perplexing character is its unusual economic coordinates: whereas the ego is organized around preserving itself and maintaining its homeostasis, traumatophilia involves processes that look, and are, wasteful rather than productive, use-less rather than use-full, and that flamboyantly pursue the “more and more” of experience without regard for conservation. Such pursuing does not follow the contractual obligations of affirmative consent but relies, rather, on limit consent. Limit consent does not involve an other who respects our limits but a surrender to an other whose opacity may besiege us and, also, a surrender to the opacity in ourselves. In the clinical setting and beyond, traumatophilia may appear destructive, senseless, or like unconstrained discharge—what de M'Uzan called “slaves of quantity” (2003, p. 711). But it is not. I owe to Bataille and to his theorizing of the notion of general economy and expenditure the possibility to formulate this: wasteful expenditure and useless squandering without a determinate end are not the same as acting out. Instead, they may open up to a different kind of possibility—of making contact with experience.

I just presented you with a lot of new conceptual material, so let me put it into contact with the race play between Williams-Haas and Haas. While much can, and has, been said about *Williams's* race vis-à-vis repetition (Cruz, 2016; Musser, 2014), Haas's Whiteness is treated as unremarkable—as if any White man, given the chance, would jump at the opportunity to sexually dominate a Black woman. In fact, finding White men who were willing to racially debase her had been quite difficult: “most ‘white folks,’” she reports, “are MORE uncomfortable around this than you know” (2009a) think, here, of *Slave Play's* Jim.¹⁷ So here is a bit more about Haas's Whiteness from *The Artist and the Pervert*:

GEORG HAAS: I grew up in a way that seems very idyllic if you look at it from the outside . . . [in a small town] in Austria, close to the

Swiss border. I had a very sheltered childhood, spent a lot time in nature. But this idyll was a lie.

We then hear from his mother, Rolanda Haas:

ROLANDA HAAS: My husband stood in front of me, a bouquet of dark red roses rested on my bosom, and he said, “You gave birth to a blond son.” [*The film cuts to a photo of baby Georg with a lock of blond hair next to it.*] You can’t imagine what a miracle that was. He grew up like any other boy. He was a sweet child. He was a good and smart boy. He was happy.

Then the film cuts to the adult Haas, who recounts,

GH: You have to imagine it like this: They had absolute power. The father is the Führer. The mother is the Führerin. My grandparents were Nazis. They were murderers. My parents were Nazis. My mother still is. They were perpetrators who, after the war, perceived themselves as a persecuted minority of “decent” people.

We return to the mother’s interview:

RH: Not National Socialist. Because that was over. Of course, back then, we were. But . . . those were the times. We understood it was wrong. The Allied forces dissociated us from all that. But . . . well . . . how shall I say? . . . At home, Georg was brought up and taught in this way. I had no idea that he has a Black girlfriend. He knew about . . . my racial hatred. . . You should keep yourself, your race, pure—purity in the sense of keeping your being. . . Now I am getting myself into things I didn’t want to say . . .

The fact that Haas comes from a family of unrepentant Nazis adds a whole other layer to the way we may view his position as “Master.” And it also offers us an unusual opportunity to turn the lens on the White member of a race-play dyad. Haas is greatly ashamed of and anguished by this lineage, but it is one under the weight of which he has to live. We are “all at base always abject,” Darieck Scott writes, “abject to histo-

ries we cannot unmake” (2021, p. 2). Haas’s past puts a different stamp on the couple’s Master/slave relationship: it helps us discern that it is not just Williams-Haas but also he who may be touching generational wounds. If, through race play, Williams-Haas is touching the wound of slavery and racism, for Haas, it may well be that the wound he is trying to touch is that of his family’s Nazi and totalitarian history—and how that is reproduced in his upbringing. This makes the dynamics of their relationship more exigent for both of them. Rather than drained of its historical specificity, their relationship may work precisely *because* of their histories, which are distinct but, in some ways, also matched.

Such a couple, a White man, the descendant of Nazis, identifying as a “Master” and a Black woman, descended from slaves, identifying as his “slave,” appears as a repetition of historical harms. But I would suggest that their coupling reveals race play as a medium that brings something into presence. As such—although there is no way to know this for sure—a partner who was not herself constellated by a comparable wound might not work as well for Haas any more than a non-White partner might work for Williams-Haas. Racialization thus proves substantive: desire, here, is not “color-blind,” it does not transcend, but is rooted in racial difference.

Wanting us to imagine beyond “false consciousness [as] the only explanation for black subjects who garner pleasure from race,” Nash urges us to read interracial couplings “‘against the grain’—against prevailing conceptualizations of racialization— . . . to engender theoretical and political space” that explores what use can be made of “racialized fictions that have shaped . . . sexual imagination[s]” (2014, pp. 84, 87, 89). Daring to claim a different way into such pleasures, Nash opens up paths for us to think about interracial desire in a less constrained fashion, giving us access points to consider how racial difference may be critical to some erotic arrangements, without being exploitatively fetishistic. Haas, for example, as the documentary shows, is not merely a purveyor of Whiteness for Williams-Haas (which would correspond to a fetishistic flattening of his subjectivity), even as his Whiteness is anything but redundant to their erotic scripts. In other words, the fact that Williams-Haas needs her sadistic lover to be White does not have to mean that *any* White person would do, any more than any Black person would work for him. What his Whiteness may harvest for her could be the force of possibility

for the touching of wounds. Similarly, Williams-Haas's racialization may also be key for Haas: in other words, neither is her race incidental (it is a meaningful feature of who she is), nor does it override her personhood to flatten her into a trope—and the documentary offers many and varied examples of that. Of course, their wounds are not the same, nor are they complementary; but they may nonetheless be a “good-enough fit” for their coupling, showing us how a pairing like Williams-Haas and Haas's, which at first glance appears to repeat horrific histories, both draws on and resists rote repetition.

We encountered earlier Williams-Haas's refusal to prioritize the uplifting of her race over the singularity of her desire. Her refusal to be fully claimed by her identity (in this case, her racial identity) and her willingness to meet Haas outside the confines of what feels politically correct can generate extraordinary intimacies that reach into territories that have little to do with recognition or with feeling validated (both of these are the ego's project) but that may instead lean into emotionally risky, not to mention politically controversial, terrain.

A traumatophobic analysis of Williams-Haas and Haas's Master/slave relationship would be to see both as repeating their intergenerationally transmitted histories. But what would that offer us other than simply reinscribing what we think we already know about Black and White relations in slavery's aftermath or about totalitarian legacies? Further, such a framework does not necessarily grant Williams-Haas or Haas the possibility of new translational capacities: it affixes them, instead, to a filled-in traumatic past. In contrast, a traumatophilic lens can enable us to see their repetitions as a way of their stepping into the fray together, of bringing the past into presence by reopening its implantative dimension. This is where the possibilities of overwhelm and for the new reside, because the only way that filled-in trauma can be wrested from its tight semiotic encasements is if the implantative dimension can be reinvigorated. It does not help that our current discourse sacralizes filled-in trauma, especially when it can be pinpointed as a factual or historical event. Psychoanalysis may well need to be dragged out of its fixation on trauma's repair, and so may queer of color critique.

Let me now return briefly to my earlier criticism of how the *New York Times* leveraged Haas's productivity as the alibi for the relationship. Traumatophilia, we saw, stands to reopen the implantative dimension

that undergirds full-fledged trauma. By agitating the “internal foreign body” (Laplanche, 2003b, p. 208), that is, untranslated enigma, a state of overwhelm may arise, followed by the kindling of new translational activity. It is in this sense that traumatophilic repetition can become a muse, stirring new drive movements, and it is such renewed drive movements that may be related to Haas’s changed relationship to his art. For Laplanche, sublimation is the domain of inspiration, which he saw as a component of sublimation. The problem with sublimation, however, is that it has been psychoanalysis’s covert way of dispensing with the problem of the drive’s insatiable press and its perverse appetites. Sublimation gives us a way of imagining a routing of the sexual’s anarchic elements to outcomes that command respect—in this case, Haas’s increased productivity. Sublimation, in other words, is productive. This warrants caution: because sublimation seeks to quell the sexual drive by directing it toward socially acceptable end products, it is more likely to enroll it into goals that are more about adaptations to the existing social order and that implicate the subject into the capitalist production—and productivity—machine. By idealizing sublimation and championing creativity, psychoanalysis tends to reify the logics of productivity. For this reason, because sublimation seeks to organize psychic energy and thus to quell its intensities, I would disagree with Laplanche’s idea that inspiration and sublimation are of kin. Rather, I see sublimation as belonging to the order of translation, that is, as trying to master and tame the unconscious. Also importantly, the transformation of the libido into “socially useful” achievements is acceptable when it comes to artistic and cultural productions (like Haas’s) or professional pursuits (as in an aggressive man who becomes a successful surgeon), but we hit a wall when it comes to sex and perversity, which will have a harder time being seen as respectable. The idea that one can sublimate rage or trauma into something productive (e.g., good poetry or beautiful art) reinforces capitalist logics—and is traumatophobic.

Inspiration, however, belongs to a different economic sphere. As the “creation of sexual energy” (Laplanche, 1980, p. 249), it is a libidinal neo-surgence, which means that it does not move us to grasp something better or understand something more accurately but moves us to invent and to imagine. Rather than keeping something immobilized or canalizing its energy, inspiration keeps it in motion. Insofar as it remains an in-

tractable force, a live wire, and an ever-renewable process in which one is in the throes of constantly pushing further—rather than a response to a ready-made reserve of energy—inspiration (rather than sublimation) is better suited as a concept to account for aesthetic transformations of the kind narrated by Haas. “You know,” Haas says, commenting on the compositions of one particular colleague, “I never liked the music. . . [It felt] cold, elusive, it just never spoke to me. At one point, I read in his autobiography that he only composed when he felt relieved of sexual tension. And what I thought, a little wickedly, was, ‘Yes, you can tell’” (Brown, 2016). Haas’s statement raises interesting questions about sexual energy and its relationship to inspiration, suggesting that it is the circulation of energy rather than its canalization that ties to inspiration.

One would be justified to ask what makes it possible for someone to be more traumatophilic as opposed to traumatophobic. How does one bend their will to turn toward trauma’s revisitation, and what are the circumstances, social, interpersonal, and intrapsychic, that may facilitate such a turn? Part of what hamstringing our ability to do different things *with* trauma is also the conceptual barricade set *around* trauma, such that trauma is only configured as harm and injury. Part of the difficulty of thinking traumatophilically, then, is that traumatophilic thinking can be itself painful, even itself a traumatism: it can wound our ideas about trauma, and it can wound those of us whose identities are organized around having survived violence. It is my contention that risking this wound is important and, even, necessary for transformation to happen. Is it sadistic to take a stance in favor of wounding? I suppose it is, though, as chapter 5 argues, this is an unusual kind of sadism, an exigent and deeply ethical one.